



Stress Signs: No Returns YTD for Nearly Half of BSE 200

MARKETS: BEATING VOLATILITY >> 8

US VISA INTERVIEW
PAUSE LEAVES
APPLICANTS IN LIMBO
>> PAGE 9

Vodka Dilutes Brown Spirits' Share among Indian Drinkers

BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE >> 9

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Nepal Floods: India Offers NDRF, Bridges, Medical Aid & More

India has offered to deploy National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) teams in Nepal to assist with search-and-rescue operations following devastating flash floods that struck Nepal on Wednesday, as at least 320 Indians remain missing and around 400 others are stranded on the Chinese side. >> 2

Centre Mulls Spl House Session for Women's Quota Bill >> 2

Nagendra bows to BJP Campaign, Resigns as Minister

Karnataka Planning and Statistics Minister B Nagendra on Friday resigned from the Cabinet amid mounting pressure from the BJP opposition over the alleged Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation scam. Nagendra, who represents Ballari Rural, said he was stepping down to prevent embarrassment to the Congress leadership, while maintaining that he was innocent. >> 3

Meta's India V-P to Join OpenAI

Sandhya Devanathan, vice president India and South-east Asia, Meta, is joining OpenAI to lead its operations in South-east Asia and Australia after a decade in the company. She will be responsible for OpenAI's growth in consumer and enterprise space, partnerships, and operations from October. >> 5

CASH & STOCK DEAL TO TRIGGER OPEN OFFER

ITC Subsidiary Will Soon Have Happiest Minds

ITC Infotech set to acquire founder Ashok Soota's 44% for about ₹2,900 cr

Pranav Mukul & Mohit Bhalla

Bengaluru|New Delhi: ITC Infotech is set to acquire a controlling stake in listed software services firm Happiest Minds Technologies from its 83-year-old founder and promoter Ashok Soota, three people familiar with the matter told ET.

ITC Infotech, a wholly owned subsidiary of tobacco-to-FMCG conglomerate ITC, is roughly twice the size of Happiest Minds by way of revenue and profit. It will acquire Soota's 44% stake, held directly and through promoter entities, for ₹2,800-2,900 crore in a combination of cash and stock, said one of the people cited above.

ET first reported in March that ITC Infotech was in discussions with Soota to potentially acquire his stake in Happiest Minds. The company had a market capitalisation of ₹6,214.34 crore at Friday's close of trading in Mumbai.

"The transaction involving the promoter stake is expected to value Happiest Minds at a premium of 5-6% over its latest market cap," said one of the people aware of discussions.

The amount does not include the payout for the mandatory open offer. The acquisition will trigger an open offer, under which ITC Infotech would seek to acquire an additional 26% from Happiest Minds' public shareholders.

Winding Road

APR 2011

Ashok Soota launches Happiest Minds

This is after stepping down as Mindtree chairman

SEPT 2020

Happiest Minds completes ₹700cr IPO

Stock lists with a pop

MAR 2026

Looks to offload 44% promoter stake in Happiest Minds

Soota begins conversations with potential buyers

AUG 2026

ITC Infotech set to acquire Happiest Minds

Will buy promoter stake for ₹2,900 cr

Once the transaction is completed, ITC Infotech is expected to reverse-merge into Happiest Minds, allowing the group's technology services arm to become a listed entity, another person said.

The infotech business is currently reflected in the consolidated balance sheet of the Kolkata-based ITC.

Queries sent to Happiest Minds and Soota remained unanswered as of Press time. ITC Infotech also did not respond to ET's emailed queries.

Mid-market Consolidation >> 8

SUMMIT ON SEPT 12-13 MARKS TWO DECADES OF GROUPING

India to Pitch CBDCs to BRICS Partners at Meet

Balanced trade, cross-border digital payments also likely to be taken up

Deepshika Sikarwar & Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: India is likely to pitch seamless cross-border digital payments, and adoption of central bank digital currencies (CBDCs) among BRICS member states at the summit it would host next month, people familiar with the deliberations told ET. New Delhi is also keen on discussions around the need for more balanced trade within BRICS, said the people cited above.

A final call on inclusion of issues for deliberations by summit leaders would be taken shortly.

The global grouping celebrates 20 years at the New Delhi summit on September 12-13.

A high-level meeting would be held next week to thrash out mechanisms for use of digital currencies, and explore ways to increase intra-BRICS trade using national currencies, said the people mentioned above.

This will, however, not be targeted against any other country.

The meeting is expected to provide clarity on the way forward on the

Building BRICS

High-level govt meeting to discuss digital currency mechanisms

National currencies could boost intra-BRICS trade

India stresses that initiative targets no other country

Fast payment system linkages also under consideration

India also seeking lower transaction costs/friction within BRICS

Customs cooperation agreement could facilitate faster trade

RBI examining cross-border CBDC transaction possibilities

RELATED REPORT >> PAGE 3

FDI Clarifications in Works to Help Investors from Land Border Nations

Ease of Capital

Govt working on FAQs on Press Note 3 of 2020

Clarification to address grey area expected shortly

Industry has raised several issues related to PN3

Concerns around paperwork, time taken

Some issues also in case of cos using Hong Kong base

Issues around PN3 to be cleared as FAQs; this will also aid those with Hong Kong base

Deepshikha Sikarwar

New Delhi: India is working on a set of clarifications to its foreign direct investment (FDI) policy aimed at providing greater clarity on rules governing investments from countries that share a land border with the co-

untry, people familiar with the matter said. "We are working on a clarification in the frequently asked questions (FAQ) format," a senior government official told ET.

These clarifications are set to provide directions to investors from countries that share land borders with India and those that enter using Hong Kong as a base. Investors have flagged several issues related to Press Note (PN) 3 of 2020 that mandates prior government approval even in sectors on the automatic route if the beneficial owner of an investment is situated in one of these countries.

Improving Ties with China >> 8

NRAI Prez: Fix Issues & Avoid Blame Games

As some of India's best-known restaurants are being called out over hygiene lapses, National Restaurant Association of India (NRAI) president Sagar Daryani said focus must be on "fixing the problem, not the blame." Ratna Bhushan reports. >> 9

Rakhi Sales on QComm Mark Large Jump

Quick-commerce platforms and brands across beauty and personal care (BPC), jewellery, snacking and more saw a surge in Raksha Bandhan orders on Friday, as last-minute gifting drove demand. Disha Acharya reports. >> 5

Bank Credit, Deposits Fall in August H1

The banking sector saw contraction in both credit and deposits outstanding in the fortnight ended August 15, RBI's latest weekly data showed. A net ₹6534 crore of deposits were withdrawn from the system in the fortnight ending August 15. >> 8

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DEATH TOLL RISES TO 579, MORE THAN 1,900 STILL MISSING

India Offers NDRF, Tunnel Rescue Teams, Medical Aid, Bridges to Nepal

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The death toll from the devastating flash floods in Nepal rose sharply on Friday, increasing by 41 within a few hours to reach 579. The number of people missing has also climbed to 1,924.

Meanwhile, India has offered to deploy National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) teams in Nepal to assist with search-and-rescue operations following devastating flash floods that struck Nepal on Wednesday, as at least 320 Indians remain missing and around 400 others are stranded on the Chinese side.

External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Friday that 96 Indian nationals who were stranded on the Chinese side had safely crossed over to Nepal by land. Separately, 21 Indians arrived in New Delhi on Friday afternoon, a day after reaching Kathmandu from the flood-affected areas of Nepal. The Tamil Nadu nationals were received at the airport by External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar.

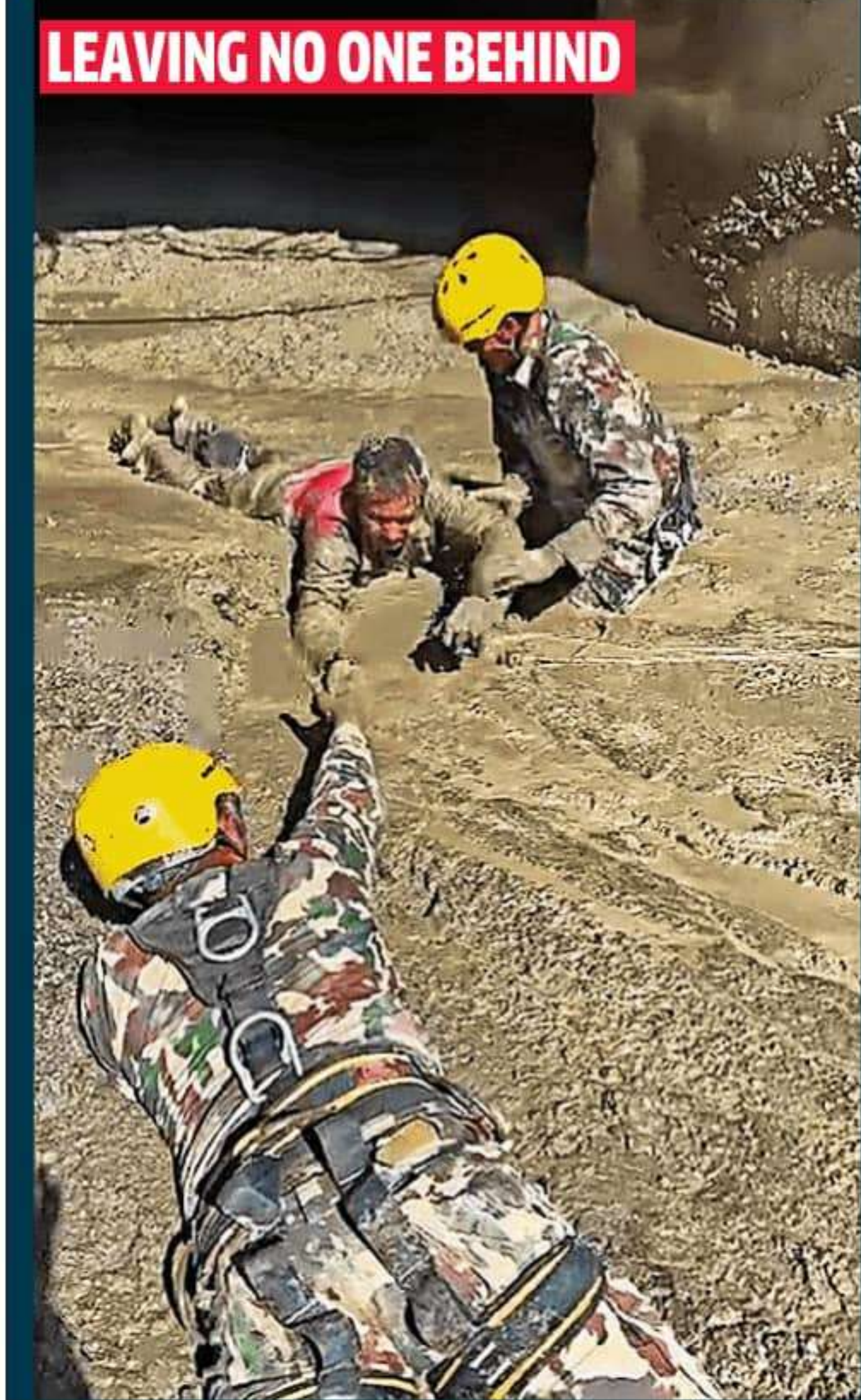
"As far as the number of people (Indians) whom we are not able to contact or who are missing, the figure at this point in time is 320," Jaiswal said. "There are also around 100 persons of Indian origin who remained uncontactable. These are people of Indian origin who may have gone for Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, but they hold other nationalities."

Jaiswal said the 400 Indians stranded on the Chinese side were safe and in touch with their families. "They have been in touch with their family. Our embassy has been in touch with several of them. Many of their family members also contacted us through the helpline numbers that our embassy is running in Beijing," he said.

"Our embassy is in touch with local authorities in China, and they are working out as to how these people who are there can be evacuated," he informed.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said India was preparing additional humani-

LEAVING NO ONE BEHIND



Nepal Army personnel rescue people trapped inside a tunnel following a mud-laden flash flood triggered by an outburst in the Bhotekoshi River, on Friday --ANI



Need to Safeguard the Fragile Ecosystem: Mirwaiz Umar Farooq

Srinagar: The devastation caused by the flash floods in Nepal and across the Himalayan region is a warning for all to safeguard the fragile ecosystem of Jammu and Kashmir, Islamic cleric Mirwaiz Umar Farooq said Friday.

Addressing the Friday congregation at the historic Jama Masjid in downtown Srinagar, he said the events in Nepal pointed to how vulnerable our mountain ecosystems have become as glaciers collapse.

Jammu and Kashmir is part of the same fragile Himalayan belt, Mirwaiz said. "We are already seeing more intense rainfall, cloudbursts, flash floods and landslides. Climate change is undoubtedly a major factor, but we must also ask whether our own pattern of development is making the situation more dangerous." —OPB

Disaster Due to Glacier Collapse in Nepal: China

Beijing: China on Friday said the collapse of a high-altitude glacier in Nepal triggered the massive flash flood disaster on Wednesday. Scientists are examining how a possible glacial collapse and ice-rock avalanche may have triggered the devastating flash floods, with preliminary assessments indicating that debris may have temporarily blocked the Lhunde River and created a landslide dam that subsequently gave way. —PTI

so that connectivity can be restored quickly in the affected parts of Nepal," he said.

Since Wednesday, India has sent a total of 47.5 tonnes of emergency supplies to Nepal in two military transport aircraft and is in the process of sending more relief materials.

"We have also made a specific offer to the Nepal authorities to dispatch NDRF teams along with their associated equipment that can help in ongoing search and rescue operations and bring relief assistance to people impacted by the tragedy. We await a response from the government of Nepal on this front. We stand ready to offer any assistance that the Nepal authorities might require," Jaiswal added.

Nepal, however, has indicated that its own security agencies are currently leading the response.

TWO-THIRDS TEST KEY TO DECISION

Centre Weighs Sept Special Session for Women's Quota Bill

Jatin Takkar

New Delhi: The Centre is mulling a short special session of Parliament in the third week of September to push through the delimitation-linked women quota bill, sources said.

The option to call an all-party meeting before that is also on the table as suggested by leader of opposition in Rajya Sabha and Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge, sources involved in the exercise said.

The move comes after Congress president and Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge wrote to Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju, urging the government to hold an all-party meeting before summoning a special session.

Two enabling bills of delimitation linked women quota are already pending with the Lok Sabha.

However, the final call will depend on whether the government is confident of securing the required two-thirds majority, sources said.

urces said.

The timing of the session remains flexible, but a third week of September sitting is increasingly seen as the preferred option.

Sources said the proposed sitting is likely to last three to four sittings with a narrowly defined agenda centred on the delimitation-linked women's quota legislation.

Although both Houses were adjourned sine die after the Monsoon Session, Parliament has not yet been prorogued.

That leaves the government with the option of reconvening the same session for a special sitting without waiting for the Winter Session, a route it had adopted earlier this year.

Government managers are simultaneously engaged in assessing the numbers needed for passage of the Constitution amendment Bills.

While the NDA's strength has improved in recent months following shifts in the political landscape and support from new allies and defectors, sources said the government is still working to secure the numbers required for a constitutional amendment.

The decision on the special session hinges as much on political arithmetic as on parliamentary scheduling. If the government is satisfied about the numbers, it could move quickly to convene the session in September. Otherwise, it may opt to prorogue the Monsoon Session and defer the exercise until a more favourable political window.

A FEW SITTINGS ONLY

Govt may hold 3-4-sitting session in third week of Sept, with delimitation-linked legislation as sole focus



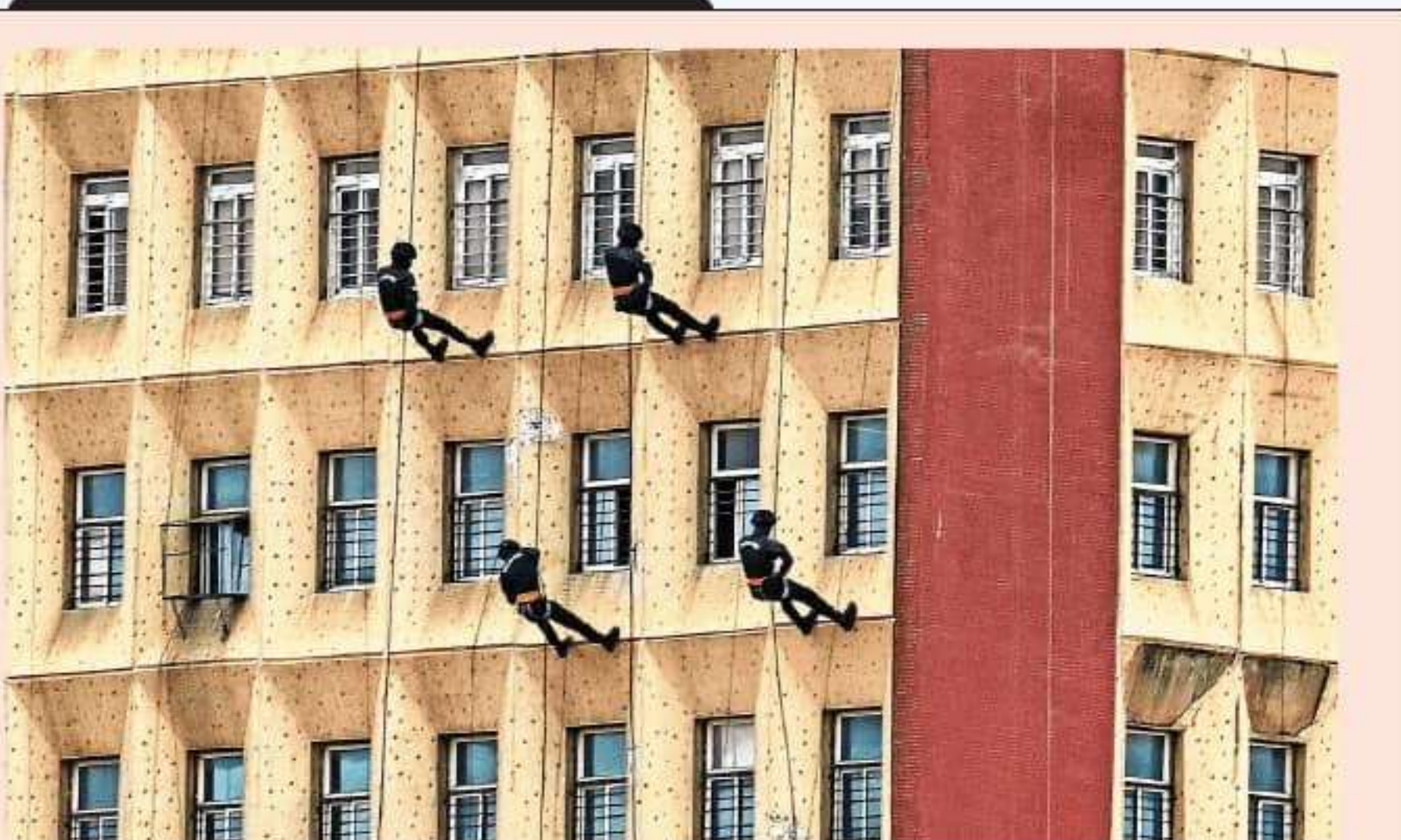
OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

Centre Appoints 2 Directors, Joint Director to National Testing Agency

New Delhi: The Centre has appointed two directors and a joint director to the National Testing Agency (NTA), which has been facing flak for issues related to the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) paper leak, among other concerns.

Ravi Kumar Singh (Indian Police Service officer) and Prasanna Venkatesh V, an Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer, have been appointed as directors in the NTA, according to separate orders dated August 27, issued by the personnel ministry.

Amit Samdaryia, a 2016 batch Indian Revenue Service (Customs and Indirect Taxes) officer, has been selected for appointment as joint director in the NTA, an order issued by the personnel ministry said. All three orders referenced a circular from the personnel ministry stating that the appointed officers must assume their new positions within three weeks of the orders' issuance. "Failing which the process of debarment from the Central Staffing Scheme shall be initiated." —PTI



FOR SHARPER RESPONSE

NSG personnel demonstrate during the opening ceremony of a comprehensive capacity-building training programme for the Karnataka police—Agencies



DMK Chief Stalin Restructures Party, Expands District Units to 110

Chennai: DMK chief M K Stalin on Friday announced a major administrative restructuring in his party, expanding the number of organisational districts to 110 from the current 77, on a day marking his entry into ninth year as party president.

The move to redraw the districts comes ahead of the party's organisational polls. The party had favoured sweeping structural overhaul, and inducting young blood during the party's executive committee meeting held at Anna Arivalayam, the DMK state headquarters here on August 22. The principal opposition, DMK, which unveiled a structural overhaul in its organisation, fixed strict age caps and limited term for party posts following its electoral setback in the April 2026 Assembly election.

Under the new delineation strategy recommended by the party reorganisation committee, constituency boundaries have been redistributed to create the 110 updated party districts. —PTI

16-DAY PROTEST CONTINUES IN PUNE

Congress Inciting Tribal Students to 'Relaunch' Rahul: BJP

Our Political Bureau

Mumbai: As the hunger strike by tribal students in Maharashtra entered its 16th day on Friday, the Bharatiya Janata Party accused the Congress of inciting the students to continue their fast to "resurrect the career of Rahul Gandhi". The BJP said the government had accepted most of the demands of the tribal students, but alleged that they were being encouraged to continue their protest with an eye on a proposed visit by Gandhi to Maharashtra.

"The government has held several rounds of meetings with the tribal students and we have accepted most of their demands and are keen to resolve the issues faced by the tribal students. Unfortunately, some Congress leaders are keen to see that the strike continues. They want the strike to continue until Rahul Gandhi's upcoming Maharashtra visit," said Navnath Ban, BJP spokesperson.

Ban was referring to Gandhi's probable visit to Nashik, where the Congress is holding a 10-day training camp for its district and city unit chiefs. Gandhi may address the

session on September 2. "The Congress wants to revive Rahul Gandhi's career; they want to relaunch him, again, so with an eye on that they are planning to get (tribal) students who are in no way connected to politics to participate in a march. This is an unfortunate attempt to shoot from the students shoulders by the Congress to target the BJP government," said Ban.

The fast by tribal students in Pune did not get much traction until one of the agitating students narrated their demands to Gandhi during his visit to Pune. The Congress leader immediately wrote to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis on the issue.

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LEADERS FROM ACROSS THE COUNTRY INVITED

BJP Chief Nabin to Meet 'Special-45' for Youth Connect

PM recently urged out-of-the-box thinking to connect with younger voters

Kumar Anshuman

New Delhi: The BJP is going full throttle to reorient itself and come up with ideas that can help it connect better with youth ahead of crucial assembly elections.

Continuing with its recent initiative on Gen Z outreach, BJP national president Nitin Nabin has called a meeting of 45 leaders, different from the earlier

group, to discuss ways to strengthen the party's youth connect. Harish Dwivedi, the recently appointed general secretary of the BJP, is coordinating the meeting.

The leaders will brainstorm the party's upcoming strategies, particularly those concerning young voters.

The 'Special-45' includes Union ministers, MPs, former MPs and other party leaders.

Among those attending the meeting are Union ministers Kamlesh Paswan and Raksha Khadse, former Union minister Anurag Thakur, Gorakhpur MP Ravi Kish-

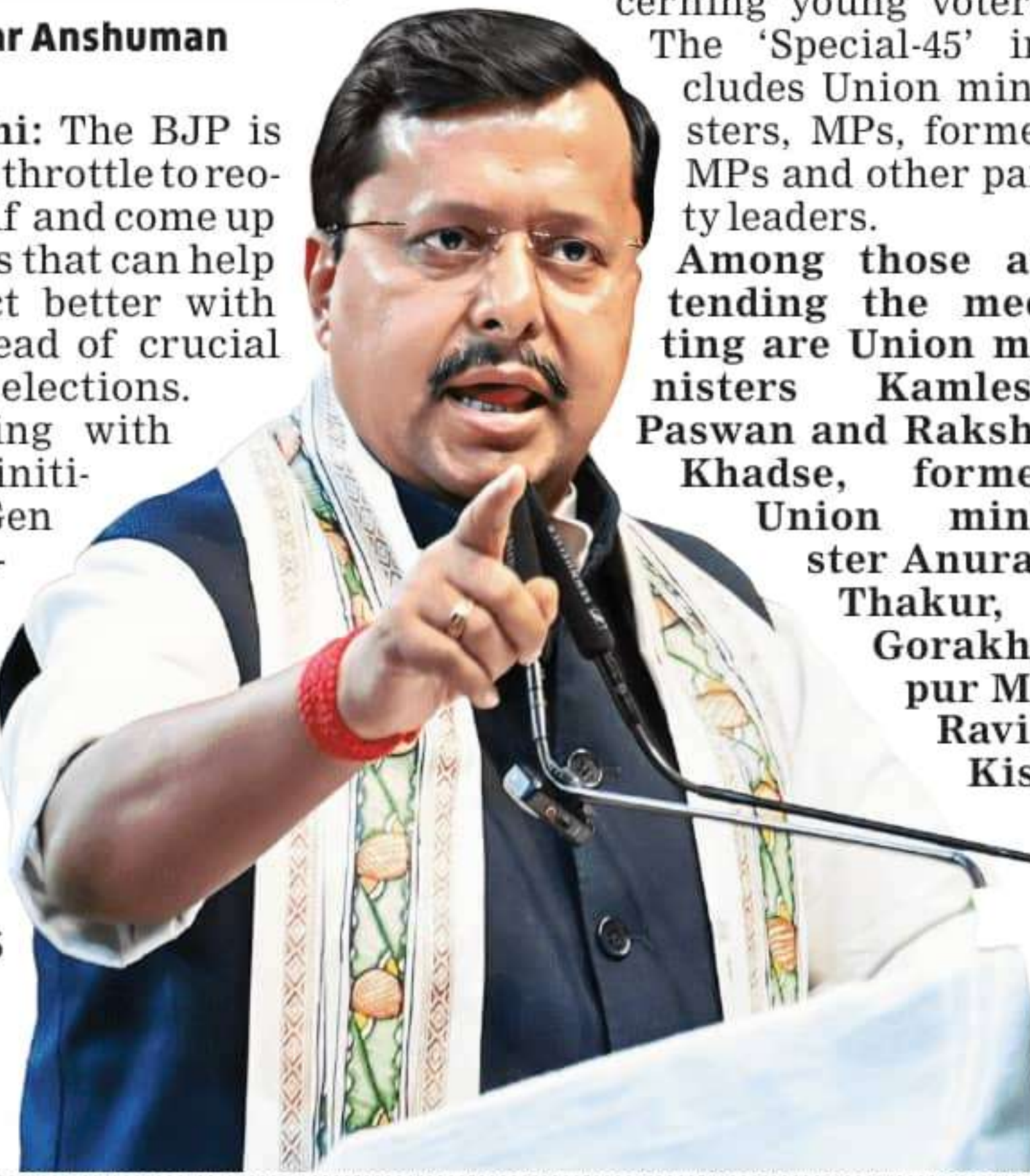
han, former BJP Yuva Morcha president and Bangalore South MP Tejasvi Surya, Darjeeling MP Raju Bisht, former Mumbai MP Poonam Mahajan and former Maharashtra minister Pankaja Munde.

Sources in the BJP told ET that the meeting is part of an exercise to brainstorm and think afresh within the party.

During the first BJP office-bearers' meeting of the new team, PM Modi had called for a new approach, asking leaders to inject new ideas that the party can work on in the coming years. His message was to think out of the box and implement ideas that can connect with the current generation of voters.

Young voters will be crucial for the party in the upcoming polls in UP, Uttarakhand and Punjab. In UP and Uttarakhand, the BJP has been in power for two terms, and the party is looking for new ideas to minimise the anti-incumbency that sets in with two consecutive terms.

In Punjab, the BJP is playing aggressively to become a key player in state politics. It currently has two MLAs in the state.



Diaspora-led Independent Platforms Aid Sangh's Expanding Global Reach

Jatin Takkar

New Delhi: As the RSS steps up its global engagement, it is increasingly leveraging independent platforms set up by NRIs and others to expand its outreach abroad.

Organisations such as American Hindus for Engagement and Dialogue (AHEAD) in the US and Integral in the UK are emerging as key facilitators of this engagement, a model the Sangh is expected to replicate in other countries.

The strategy is on display during RSS Chief Mohan Bhagwat's ongoing tour of the US, Canada and the UK.

The highlight of the US leg will be his address at the Universal Oneness Celebration at Madison Square Garden's Infosys Theatre in New York on Saturday. Organised by AHEAD, the event is expected to bring together invitees from social, religious and community organisations.

Bhagwat will then travel to Toronto before visiting London from September 2 to 7, where, apart from interacting with the Indian diaspora, he is expected to hold interfaith meetings with representatives of the Jewish, Christian, Sikh and Muslim communities.



RSS Chief Mohan Bhagwat at John F Kennedy International Airport — PTI

its role as the BJP's ideological mentor and its growing visibility in India's public life, the organisation is seeking to engage directly with opinion-makers, governments, academics and faith leaders rather than allowing others to define its image.

RSS functionaries say the objective is to address what they describe as "misgivings" about the organisation and Hindutva, while presenting the Sangh's worldview through India's civilisational ethos and philosophical traditions.

According to them, the dialogue seeks to offer Indian perspectives on social harmony and contemporary global challenges.

The outreach has gathered momentum over the past year. RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale has visited Germany, while Akhil Bharatiya Prachar Pramukh Sunil Ambekar travelled to Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan and is expected to accompany Bhagwat during the UK leg. Sources said RSS functionaries have also remained in regular touch with Indian missions in the UK and across the European Union.

At the centre of this strategy is an expanding network of organisations created by sympathisers and members of the Indian diaspora.

Alongside the Hindu Swamyasevak Sangh, platforms such as AHEAD and Integral function independently but can be described as 'Friends of RSS'.

Guj Launches Sports Genomics Programme

DP Bhattacharya

Gandhinagar: In a first of its kind initiative, Gujarat has launched a state-level 'sports genomics programme' aimed at understanding the genetic, physiological and performance characteristics of its athletes, that could add a new scientific dimension to athlete development.

The initiative also assumes significance in the context of Gujarat's preparations for the 2030 Commonwealth Games. Scientific athlete profiling could potentially support efforts to identify and prepare athletes capable of competing at national and international levels.

Sport genomics is an emerging field that studies the relationship between genetic variations and athletic characteristics such as muscle composition, endurance, metabolism, exercise response, recovery and injury susceptibility.

OVER ALLEGED VALMIKI CORP SCAM

Nagendra Resigns, BJP says its Fight against Cong to Continue

Minister says he's quitting to prevent embarrassment to Congress and he's innocent

Our Bureau
Bengaluru: Karnataka Planning and Statistics Minister B Nagendra on Friday resigned from the Cabinet amid mounting pressure from the BJP opposition over the alleged Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation scam.

Nagendra, who represents Ballari Rural, said he was stepping down to prevent embarrassment to the Congress leadership, while maintaining that he was innocent. He also said he was willing to resign his assembly seat to prove his innocence. The BJP claimed the resignation as a victory and said it would continue its campaign against the Con-



B Nagendra addresses the media in Bengaluru on Friday.

gress government until the 2028 assembly elections.
Chief Minister DK Shivakumar had inducted Nagendra into the Cabinet on August 3 after a state Special Investigation Team (SIT) probe gave him a clean chit in the

case involving alleged diversion of funds from the Valmiki corporation to private bank accounts.

The BJP had disrupted assembly proceedings and staged an overnight protest demanding Nagendra's removal.

Nagendra had earlier resigned as Scheduled Tribes Welfare Minister in 2024 after allegations emerged of financial irregularities in the corporation, which implements welfare programmes for Scheduled Tribe communities. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) subsequently arrested him in July 2024 in connection with its money-laundering investigation.

The case centres on the alleged illegal transfer of ₹89.63 crore from the corporation's account with

Union Bank of India to accounts of unidentified recipients in Hyderabad between February 21 and May 6, 2024.

The bank told the CBI that it had recovered about ₹5 crore, leaving ₹84.63 crore unrecovered.

The issue has remained politically contentious, with Opposition leader R Ashoka alleging in the assembly that Congress leaders benefited from the alleged scam and accusing the government of shielding Nagendra.

In May 2024, P Chandrashekar, an accounts superintendent with the corporation, died by suicide, leaving a note alleging that senior officials had pressured him to facilitate parallel bank accounts for diversion of funds.

No Karnataka Route in Centre's Rail-quadrupling Plan: MB Patil

State willing to share 50% of cost of railway projects to speed up their implementation



Our Bureau

Bengaluru: No railway route in Karnataka has been included in the Centre's plan to quadruple seven high-density railway routes across the country, infrastructure development minister MB Patil said Friday, calling it an injustice to the state.

The Centre recently announced plans to upgrade seven high-density routes—Delhi-Howrah, Howrah-Chennai, Chennai-Mumbai, Mumbai-Delhi, Delhi-Chennai, Mumbai-Howrah and Delhi-Guwahati—into four-line corridors to improve passenger and freight movement, the minister said in a statement.

Patil said Karnataka also has several high-density routes, including Bengaluru-Pune-Mumbai, Bengaluru-Mysuru, Bengaluru-Mangaluru, Bengaluru-Chennai, Bengaluru-Shivamogga, Bengaluru-Vijayapura and Bengaluru-Kalaburagi, which should be developed as four-track corridors.

He said he would urge chief minister Siddaramaiah to write to the Centre and seek a meeting with Union railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw to raise the issue.

Patil also flagged inadequate rail connectivity between Karnataka's coastal towns, including Mangaluru, Bhatkal, Honnavar, Kundapura and Karwar, and major centres

such as Bengaluru, Shivamogga and Hubballi.

Karnataka has a 330-km coastline and better rail connectivity to its coastal ports is needed to improve links with the hinterland, Patil said. The lack of rail capacity has also put additional pressure on the state's highways, he said.

He also said that the Centre's plan for high-speed rail links between Bengaluru and Chennai and Bengaluru and Hyderabad, would have limited coverage within Karnataka. Patil further added that he had sought a high-speed rail corridor between Bengaluru, Hubballi and Pune.

The state is willing to share 50% of the cost of railway projects to speed up their implementation, Patil said, adding that Karnataka was not receiving the same priority as Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh.

The minister also said that the centre did not respond positively to his proposal for the development of high-speed rail corridor on the Bengaluru-Hubballi-Pune route.

MADE BY JV BETWEEN RTX AND LOCKHEED MARTIN

India, US Sign Deal for Javelin Anti-Tank Missiles

Javelin anti-tank missile

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Indian army has signed a deal to purchase Javelin anti-tank guided missiles from the US under a government to government initiative.

The \$45.7 million deal is to acquire over 100 of the missiles that will be delivered on a fast track basis.

The US Embassy in Delhi welcomed the signing of a Letter of Offer

and Acceptance (LOA) for the purchase through the U.S. Foreign Military Sales process.

"The milestone reflects the enduring partnership between the U.S. and Indian Armed Forces and opens the door for future collaboration to acquire over 100 of the missiles that will be delivered on a fast track basis between the U.S. and Indian defense industries," the statement read.

US Ambassador to India Sergio

Gor too welcomed the agreement, saying it reflects a growing defence partnership between the two nations.

"The Javelin agreement demonstrates the depth of U.S. support for the Indian Army and creates new opportunities for our defense industries to work together. We see tremendous potential for future cooperation that strengthens the defense industrial bases of both countries," he said.

Amarnath Yatra Ends

Press Trust of India

Srinagar: The 57-day annual Amarnath Yatra formally concluded on Friday with the arrival of the 'Chhari-Mubarak' -- the saffron-robed holy mace of Lord Shiva -- at the 3,880-metre-high cave shrine in the south Kashmir Himalayas for special prayers, officials said.

The conclusion of the yatra, which began on July 3, coincided with the festival of Raksha Bandhan and came nearly three weeks after the pilgrimage was suspended for the year on August 9 due to damage to the track and adverse weather conditions. The 'Chhari-Mubarak', carried by a group of sadhus led by its custodian Mahant Dipendra Giri, reached the holy cave in the early hours of Friday after the group trekked six kilometres from the Sheshnag halting station, officials said.

Special prayers were held at the cave shrine following the arrival of the holy mace.

BRICS Set to Adopt Framework for Supply-Chain Cooperation

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: India will use its BRICS chairship to push the grouping towards practical, development-oriented outcomes in startups, innovation, resilient supply chains and green energy, while seeking greater trade in national currencies and reforms of global institutions at the 18th BRICS Summit on September 12-13.

India's chairship is guided by the theme 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability', reflecting Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of a people-centric approach rooted in the spirit of 'humanity first', an official said.

Amid pressure on global supply chains due to conflicts, the summit is expected to adopt a BRICS Logistics Supply-Chain Cooperation Framework to strengthen the resilience, efficiency and sustainability of cross-sector transport logistics and supply chains among Brics members. BRICS Logistics Supply-Chain Cooperation Framework is a voluntary, consensus-based framework to strengthen cross-sector transport logistics resilience and sustainability.

It aims to address fragmented supply chains and weak connectivity by promoting technical exchange, knowledge sharing on cargo and



Artists during the BRICS Cultural Summit at Ravindra Bhawan in Bhopal

shipping services, localized assembly and manufacturing ecosystems, and capacity building, while advancing environmentally sustainable and climate-resilient logistics practices.

A digital interface could also be cre-

ated to connect national nodal agencies, selected incubators and startups across BRICS countries. India will also push for reforms of global institutions, including the UN, IMF and World Bank, while promoting trade in national currencies.

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Adhikari Slams 'Azadi' Slogans at JU, Says Time to end Threat Culture

Jayatri Nag

Kolkata: West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Friday said it is time to end the "threat culture" at Jadavpur University and vowed to restore nationalism inside and outside the campus.

Adhikari slammed those raising 'Azadi' slogans and writing 'Red Salute Kishanji' on the walls of Jadavpur University (JU).

"It pains me when 'Azadi' slogans are raised on the streets of the city. What is this Azadi for? The country became independent long ago." The CM has organised a "Vande Mataram" singing ceremony in Jadavpur area, in front of JU, and will himself sing the national song in the programme titled "Vande Mataram in 10,000 voices".

"From the soil of West Bengal, Khudiram Bose gave 'Azadi' to India. On the soil of West Bengal, Matangini Hazra — with the tricolour in one hand and taking British bullets — gave us our independence. Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, Rishi Aurobindo, Rashtraguru Surendranath Banerjee, Binoy Badal, Dinesh, Masterda Surya Sen and the countless sacrifices of our freedom fighters — that is how we gained independence.

Whose Azadi do you want?" Adhikari questioned while addressing the gathering from Jadavpur, just opposite Jadavpur University.

Several times, slogans of Kashmir Maange Azadi have been raised from Jadavpur.

ROW OVER LEARNING MARATHI BY MIGRANT TAXI & AUTO DRIVERS

MNS, UBT Sena Slam Fadnavis Over Marathi Rule Extension for Drivers

The decision was reversed with an eye on UP polls: Amit Thackeray

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: The move by chief minister Devendra Fadnavis to give a one year extension to migrant taxi and auto drivers to learn Marathi has not gone down well with the Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray Shiv Sena as well as the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena who have alleged that the government took the step with an eye on the upcoming Uttar Pradesh polls.

"We have understood how much affection you have for the Marathi language and for our state, you can give them a 10-15 year extension too. Every other state be it Gujarat, Punjab or southern states take pride in their own language, however, here the decision



is reversed with an eye on the Uttar Pradesh assembly polls," said Amit Thackeray, son of MNS president Raj Thackeray.

UBT Sena MP Sanjay Raut also slammed the state government's move claiming that there was political pressure from the BJP leadership in Delhi on the state government to give an extension to the migrant auto and cab drivers with an eye on upcoming

elections. "The government is acting on the whims of what their masters in Delhi are saying and in the process they have sacrificed the pride of the local language. Other states have made knowing their local language mandatory like West Bengal, Karnataka. Those providing public service while earning their livelihood should respect and communicate in the local language that is Marathi," said Raut.

The UBT MP slammed the Shiv Sena (Shinde) for being silent on the Chief Minister's decision to give a year's extension. "They (Shiv Sena) keep talking of Marathi pride but if they had any self respect they should walk out of the cabinet in protest against the decision," said Raut.

India's First Dedicated Quantum & AI Varsity to Come Up in Amaravati

Andhra's 8.5-acre NIELIT campus plans to train 8,250 learners

Our Bureau

Hyderabad: Andhra Pradesh's capital Amaravati is set to get India's first dedicated university campus for quantum technologies and artificial intelligence after the state government approved a ₹730.7-crore National Institute of Electronics and Information Technology (NIELIT) campus. It is part of the state Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu's efforts to build a deep-tech and quantum computing ecosystem in the state.

The 8.5-acre campus will be funded through a grant from the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY).

Classes are expected to begin from September 2026 at a temporary facility at



Acharya Nagarjuna University in Guntur, before shifting to the permanent Amaravati campus.

Courses will cover quantum computing and communication, AI and machine learning, semiconductor fabrication, chip design, VLSI, embedded systems and high-performance computing.

The university will also house a 1.25 lakh sq ft Quantum Research, Innovation &

Incubation Block with quantum computing and photonics facilities, cleanroom and nano-fabrication infrastructure, semiconductor and chip-design labs, data centres and startup incubation spaces.

The project aims to train around 8,250 learners over five years, including 1,650 through degree programmes and 6,600 through skilling and certification programmes.

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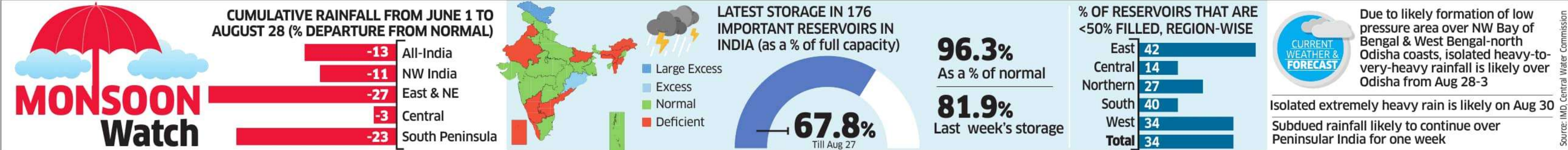
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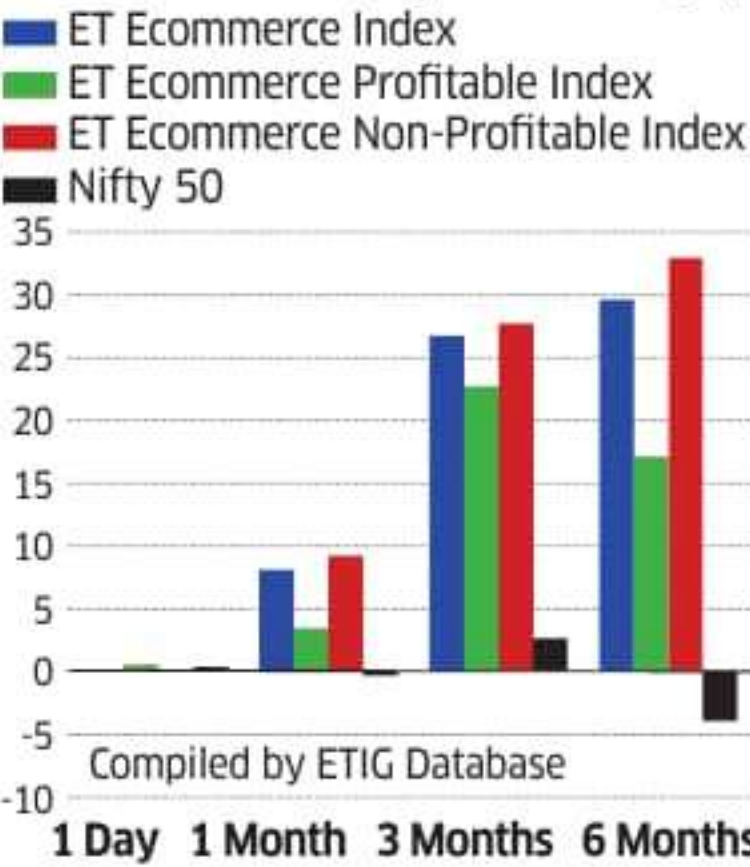


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Tech Buzz

Tencent's New AI Model for Coding is Out



Tencent released a preview version of a new open-source AI model aimed at tasks such as software engineering, research and financial analysis, according to its post on Hugging Face, a repository of open-source AI models. The model, called Hy4 preview, uses a "mixture-of-experts" design with 770 billion parameters in total, Tencent said, although only about 49 billion are used for any given text request. The firm said it plans to integrate the model alongside Tencent products, including CodeBuddy and WorkBuddy. Tencent added that early-release model can sometimes take longer than necessary to work through complex questions and may over-verify its own answers. - Reuters

3,000+
Customers identity verification startup serves in over 190 countries. - Reuters

Sandhya Devanathan Exits Meta

To Join OpenAI as SE Asia and Australia Ops Chief

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Sandhya Devanathan, vice president India and Southeast Asia, Meta, is joining OpenAI to lead its operations in Southeast Asia and Australia after a decade in the company. She will be based in Singapore and report to Kiran Mani, managing director, Asia Pacific region for OpenAI. In her new role, Devanathan will be responsible for OpenAI's growth in consumer and enterprise space, partnerships, and operations from October 2026 as the company ramps up their operations in the region. She will also be engaging with regulators in the region. Over the past two years, OpenAI has opened local offices in Singapore, Tokyo, Seoul, Sydney and Delhi.

India to Pitch Inclusive, Ethical AI Agenda at Kyrgyzstan SCO Summit

AI governance talks may pit New Delhi's 'seven chakras' against China's multilateral body

Subhayan Chakraborty

New Delhi: India will pursue its global agenda of accessible and inclusive artificial intelligence rooted in moral and ethical systems at the upcoming Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) leaders summit in Kyrgyzstan, amid major efforts by China to pull SCO nations closer on AI, officials told ET. Talks on global AI governance will be on the agenda during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Bishkek for the two-day summit beginning August 31, they said. The 25th SCO summit is expected to highlight the competing visions and diverging global AI governance aspirations of the two nations.

Officials said China is expected to further popularise the Shanghai-based World AI Cooperation Organization (WAICO), established last month with support from 29 countries. These countries included eight of the 10 nations of the SCO bloc, barring India and Iran.



Last year, ET reported that India might provide cautious support to the multilateral AI body, even if it doesn't outright join.

WAICO will be guided by the provisions of the UN Charter, rely on the principle of common benefit, and adhere to a human-centred approach, China said during its launch, which saw the participation of the current SCO chair, Kazakhstan President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, and other delegates from SCO nations. Beijing also announced it would provide 5,000 quotas for participation in exchange programmes and establish cooperation centres with partners from

a range of country groupings including the BRICS and SCO.

India will continue to push for greater global cooperation based on the seven chakras framework of AI development at all international fora, an official said. These centre on the principles of development of human capital, broadening access for social empowerment, trustworthiness of AI systems, energy efficiency of AI systems, use of AI in science, democratising AI resources and use of AI for economic growth and social good. "India has positioned itself as a leading global voice in AI with February's AI Impact Summit. The New Delhi declaration was endorsed by 92 countries and international organisations. China was also a signatory," the official explained.

The SCO is a political, economic and security alliance founded by Russia, China, and the four Central Asian nations of Tajikistan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan in 2001. India and Pakistan have been members since 2017, while Iran and Belarus joined in 2023 and 2024. It is considered the most important conclave in the Central Asian region, where other nations have significant interest in trade, connectivity, and resource extraction.

AI for All

Talks on global AI governance will be on the agenda during PM Modi's visit to Bishkek for the 2-day summit beginning August 31

25th SCO summit set to highlight competing visions and diverging global AI governance aspirations of two nations

Officials said China expected to further push the Shanghai-based WAICO

Hero MotoCorp Lands 3% More Stake in Ather for ₹1,758 crore

Shares will be acquired from an existing shareholder; deal expected to close by Sept 3

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Hero MotoCorp is increasing its ownership of electric two-wheeler maker Ather Energy, picking up an about 3% more stake for ₹1,758 crore in a secondary transaction, as per an exchange filing. Shares of Ather ended 9.3% higher at ₹1,612 on the BSE Friday. The shares will be acquired from an existing shareholder and the transaction is expected

to close by September 3. Hero MotoCorp did not name the seller.

The investment comes soon after the maker of Splendor and Xpulse motorcycles invested ₹960

crore in Ather through convertible warrants. Ather's exchange filing shows Hero was allotted about 7.62 million warrants at ₹1,260 apiece. The warrants were convertible into an equal number of equity shares.

Hero continues to build its own electric vehicle business through the VIDA brand. It has increased its holding in Ather several times prior to the electric scooter maker's IPO.

The latest transaction also follows Ather's sharp increase in scale and market share since its listing last year. The company sold 263,000 electric scooters in FY26, up about 69% on-year, and increased its market share to 18.6% from 7.6% a year earlier.

Ather reported revenues of about ₹3,671 crore for the year, up from ₹2,305 crore in FY25.

The company's market capitalisation has grown from around ₹12,000 crore at the time of its IPO in April 2025 to more than ₹63,592 crore as of Friday, a more than fivefold increase. Over the same period, Hero MotoCorp's market capitalisation rose roughly 40%, from around ₹78,000 crore to ₹1.11 lakh crore.

Ather has rapidly expanded in its sales and distribution footprint. The company ended FY26 with about 700 experience centres and 548 service centres, while its sales increased to 2.63 lakh units from 1.56 lakh units. Ather has also been gaining ground outside its traditional southern markets.

TCS Cuts Q1 Mid-senior Variable Pay to 50-70% amid Margin Squeeze

Q1 variable payouts lower than bonuses rolled out in the last two quarters

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) has paid approximately a range of 50%-70% of quarterly variable pay to employees in its mid- and senior-level bands for the April-June quarter, according to people aware of the matter. However, the average payout is at least 10-20 percentage points lower than the bonuses rolled out in the preceding two quarters. Employees in select high performing business units have seen a higher

average rollout, one of the employees confirmed. However, the specifics could not be ascertained. The payout comes after a prolonged period of subdued variable compensation at the company. For nearly two years until the first quarter of fiscal 2026, mid- and senior-level employees received only about 20-40% of

their eligible variable pay. The payouts began to improve from FY26, reaching 60-80% in each of the previous two quarters. "In the previous quarters, some of us were given less than 30%...so my Q1 variable was in fact better than the previous few quarters, around 50%-55%," one employee told ET.

Meanwhile, another mid-level employee with over 15 years of experience said he received around 35-40% of variable pay. Payouts have been circumspect for other IT service providers grappling with AI-led deflation and margin pressures. India's second-largest IT firm, Infosys, for instance, paid an average performance bonus of 70% to eligible employees for the April-June quarter, unchanged from the previous quarter, but 10 percentage points lower than the year-ago period, ET reported earlier in the week.

Icertis Replaced CEO Following Whistleblower Letter: Sources

Enterprise tech co's board appointed two interim-CEOs last month

Swathi Moorthy

Bengaluru: Icertis, the \$5 billion valued enterprise tech company, replaced its CEO with two interim-CEOs last month. The company cited no reason for the change of guard that took place in less than a year. In the meantime, it has announced the search for a new CEO.

Icertis CFO Rajat Bahri and board member Jim Moffatt became interim co-CEOs, replacing Anand Subbaraman. Fresh details that are coming out point to a whistleblower complaint against Subbaraman's conduct, according to three sources. The board received this complaint in May and initiated an investigation, they said. In two months, the company announced a CEO transition.

Subbaraman, who joined the company as chief operating officer in February 2024

became CEO in August 2025. He succeeded co-founder Samir Bodas who stepped away due to illness. Bodas passed away in January 2026.

As per the company statement, Subbaraman would continue as an advisor to ensure seamless transition. But it did not specify the circumstance of the CEO transition. The whistleblower complaint, reviewed

by ET, raised allegations of favouritism. The letter alleged Subbaraman's conduct undermined the culture of fairness and transparency in the organisation.

The charges against him could not be independently verified. In response to ET's queries, an Icertis spokesperson stated that while the company does not comment on specific employee related matters, it has a defined process whereby employees may share information with the board of directors. "The Board takes all the matters brought to its attention seriously and gives them careful consideration. The Board and the team are deeply committed to stewarding the company in an ethical and responsible manner and in a way that fosters a collaborative, congenial and innovative professional environment," the statement added. Despite multiple calls, messages and email, Subbaraman did not respond to the allegations.



QComm Strikes Gold with Rapid Rakhis and Premium Gifting

Last-minute gifting and a growing preference for premium products drive huge order surge

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Quick commerce platforms and brands across beauty and personal care (BPC), jewellery, snacking and more saw a surge in Raksha Bandhan orders on Friday, as last-minute gifting and a growing preference for premium products drove demand.

Platforms like Blinkit, Zepto, Instamart, Flipkart Minutes and Amazon Now created dedicated pages on their apps featuring rakhis, gift sets, dry fruits, premium gifting, electronics and more to drive sales much before the occasion.

On Instamart, rakhi orders grew nearly 300% year-on-year (yoy) on Friday. "The festive rush peaked on August 28 at exactly 12:01 pm, when last-minute shoppers flooded the app to trigger 857 rakhis ordered per minute," the company said. Sales of gift hampers grew 85% week-on-week, smartwatches nearly doubled at 99%, and premium designer rakhis grew 130% on Instamart.

Under Amazon Now's Rakhi Store, the platform brought together over 500 unique Rakhis, festive essentials and gifting options. "This year, we saw a clear shift towards pre-

mimisation and personalisation in gifting — customers moved beyond regular options to more indulgent ones. Chocolate gifts were the fastest-growing category, up 2.5x vs. BAU, while Kajju Katli saw 2x growth vs. BAU," said Nishant Sardana, director, Amazon Now.

Demi-fine jewellery brand Palmonas, which has partnered with Blinkit, Zepto, Swiggy and MNow, has seen a 70% growth in orders from one day before Rakhi to the day of Rakhi. "While we saw a significant spike in demand for rakhis, gifting also emerged as the largest contributor — almost 60% of total stock-keeping units (SKUs) sales," said Pallavi Mohadikar, co-founder and CEO of Palmonas.

ORDERS PEAK

ET reported on August 4 that quick commerce is expected to log 14-15 million orders on August 28, up from 8-9 million a year ago.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Festive Rush

On Instamart, rakhi orders grew nearly 300% year-on-year

Sale of gift hampers grew 85% week-on-week

Amazon Now's Rakhi Store had over 500 rakhis, festive essentials and gifts

Demi-fine jewellery brand Palmonas, which partnered with Blinkit, Zepto, Swiggy and MNow, saw a 70% growth in orders

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SCAN TO REGISTER



NEW ELECTROMAGNETIC FIELD GUIDELINES IN TELECOM

Mobile Radiation Norms Eased to Global Standards

Growing 5G networks impaired by old rules; revamp ensures service quality

ET EXCLUSIVE

Kiran Rathee

New Delhi: The government has increased the electromagnetic field (EMF) limits for mobile networks to global standards, allowing telecom operators to cover larger areas with fewer towers, in a bid to ensure quality of service amid rising 5G traffic, people aware of the matter told ET. The revised EMF or radiation rules, which will come into effect next month, double the permitted power density for a 5G base tower station (BTS) to 10 watt per square metre from 5 watts at present. This will essentially help signals to travel a longer distance, allowing service providers to extend coverage from each site and reduce network expansion costs, the people said. EMF limits govern the maximum radio-frequency energy that mobile network equipment can emit. The relaxation has been a long-pending demand of the telecom industry, which had argued that the earlier limits were hampering efficient 5G coverage. "The change was essential in the wake of 5G as well as upcoming telecom technologies," said an official privy to the details. A query sent to the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) to confirm the development remained unanswered at the time of going to press on Friday. The development is

Change Game

India joins likes of EU, Australia, UK, Japan, South Korea for electromagnetic field norms

International Commission for Non-Ionizing Radiation Protection (ICNIRP) guides on environmental effects of EMF

To make amends, a partial relaxation was done in last year

Around 135 countries follow ICNIRP norms

India adopted ICNIRP norms in 2008, made them more stringent in 2012

Rules worked for 2G, 3G and 4G but can't work for 5G

Now, norms are aligned with ICNIRP

likely to be particularly helpful for Vodafone Idea, which is in the process of rolling out 5G service across the country and can now plan its network based on the higher limits, people cited above said. Bharti Airtel and Reliance Jio, which have already deployed much of their 5G networks, are also expected to benefit from lower incremental capital expenditure and more efficient use of existing sites, they said. India has been for years following much stricter radiation emission norms than those recommended by the International Commission for Non-Ionizing Radiation Protection (ICNIRP), which advises the World Health Organisation and government agencies on the health and environmental effects of EMF. For instance, the country was following a power density requirement of 1 watt per square metre, which was re-

vised to 5 watts last year, even as ICNIRP has recommended 10 watts. Telcos have been seeking rules in line with this, citing studies that show no adverse health effects from wireless technologies. The new 10 watt limit is in line with norms followed in around 137 countries including most European Union countries, the UK, Australia, Japan, South Korea and Singapore. As per the telcos, the old EMF rules have worked for 2G, 3G or 4G to an extent, but the same can't be possible for 5G due to the significant differences in standards. According to ICNIRP, some 5G communication technologies utilise higher EMF frequencies than 3G and 4G standards. "EMFs at higher frequencies produce relatively superficial exposure, with less power penetrating deep into the body," ICNIRP noted in a report.

MAY RAISE \$3.5-4B

Jio Receives Sebi Nod for Listing Plan

Likely to become largest Indian IPO, beating proposed NSE offering

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Jio Platforms (JPL), the telecom, digital and technology arm of Mukesh Ambani-led Reliance Industries, has received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to start its initial public offering, information on the regulator's website showed. Bankers estimate the IPO could raise around \$3.5-4 billion, or approximately ₹37,000 crore, which would make it potentially the largest public issue in India, dwarfing the proposed listing by the National Stock Exchange (NSE). JPL had submitted its draft IPO papers to Sebi in June and received the regulator's final observations on August 28, according to an update on Sebi's website. A Reliance statement to the two exchanges also confirmed the news. Receiving Sebi's final observations marks a key milestone in the IPO process, allowing the company to move ahead with preparations for the issue, subject to applicable regulatory requirements. As per the Draft Red Herring

Prospectus (DRHP), Jio Platforms plans to issue up to 270 million fresh equity shares, which will represent around 2.9% of the company's total equity capital after the IPO. There is no offer for sale (OFS) component in the proposed IPO. The Jio Platforms offering will be the first IPO from the Reliance Industries group in nearly two decades, following the listing of Reliance Petroleum in 2006.

FIRST RELIANCE IPO IN 20 YRS The offering will be the first IPO from Reliance Industries group in nearly two decades, after Reliance Petroleum listed in 2006

IPO PROCEEDS According to the IPO documents, a portion of the proceeds will be used to prepay up to Rs 27,500 crore of loans at Reliance Jio Infocomm Ltd (RJIL), the operating subsidiary of Jio Platforms. The remaining funds will be used for general corporate purposes. Jio Platforms may extend funds to RJIL by subscribing to its equity shares, convertible or non-convertible preference shares, debentures, or by granting loans or a mix of both, according to the DRHP.

Murdoch's Plan to Reunite News Corp & Fox Comes to Light from Unsealed Court Documents

New York: Rupert Murdoch's longstanding wish to reunite Fox Corp and News Corp could resurface in a potential merger that would bring together a television company and a sprawling news operation, consolidating his family's control over a smaller media empire, according to court documents and video. Discussions about a possible re-merger emerged in recent weeks from unsealed court documents and attorney testi-

mony linked to a family succession dispute that began in 2023. The judicial official overseeing the case released the findings at the end of July. The documents showed that in 2022, Murdoch became interested in recombining the companies less than a decade after splitting them. That effort failed after investors objected, but court proceedings in June indicated Murdoch could make another attempt. Reuters

ADDENDUM TO PUBLIC NOTICE – FIFTH E-AUCTION DATED 08.08.2026			
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As per Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016			
E-mail id: ivrcl.liquidation@gmail.com, www.ivrcl.com			
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Sale of Assets under Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016			
In respect of auction sale notice issued by the undersigned on 08.08.2026 for sale through e-auction of IVRCL Limited, the timelines of the said process are revised as under. The Sale will be done by the undersigned through the E-Auction platform at the web portal https://ibbi.bsanetk.com/e-auction-ibbi/home . Brief particulars of the sale are as follows:			
Description	As per the Auction Notice	As Amended	
Category A - Sale of Corporate Debtor as a Going Concern	01.09.2026	17.09.2026	
Asset Set 1: Sale of Corporate Debtor as a going concern on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" AND "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS"	at 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM	at 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM	
Category B - Sale of Investments of the CD (In case no bids are received for auction under Category A)	01.09.2026 at 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM	17.09.2026 at 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM	
Asset Set 2: Sale of Investments of the CD in Salem Tollways Limited & Kumarpallayam Tollways Limited (SPVs) being part of assets of the CD on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" AND "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS"	01.09.2026 at 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM	17.09.2026 at 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM	
Asset Set 3: Sale of shares of CD holding in IOT Ukai Energy Services Limited being part of assets of the CD on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" AND "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS"	01.09.2026 at 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM	17.09.2026 at 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM	
Category C - Sale of Non-Core Assets of the CD (In case no bids are received for auction under Category A)	01.09.2026 at 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM	17.09.2026 at 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM	
Asset Set 4: Sale of individual asset(s) being part of non-core assets of the CD as further listed in "Non-core Assets Part 1" on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" AND "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS"	Between 10:00 AM to 5:00 PM from August 08, 2026 to August 30, 2026	Between 10:00 AM to 5:00 PM III September 15, 2026.	
Last Date for Submission of Documents & EMD	August 30, 2026 before 05:00 PM.	September 15, 2026 before 05:00 PM.	
Site Visits	Between 10:00 AM to 5:00 PM from August 08, 2026 to August 30, 2026	Between 10:00 AM to 5:00 PM III September 15, 2026.	
All other terms & conditions shall remain the same.			
Date: August 29, 2026	Purusottam Behera		
Place: Hyderabad	Liquidator of IVRCL Limited		
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	Email ID – ivrcl.liquidation@gmail.com		

Dear Shareholders,

It gives me immense pleasure to welcome you all for the 63rd Annual General Meeting of Hindustan Aeronautics Limited.

I am pleased to share your Company's annual performance highlights for the Financial Year 2025-26. During the year, despite of supply chain disruption caused by the current global scenario, the Company's performance was impressive and considerable progress was made in terms of revenue, profitability, order book and productivity.

This achievement would not have been possible without the strong commitment of our people, the trust of our esteemed customers, support from the government and backing of our shareholders. I, on behalf of the Board of Directors, sincerely thank each one of you for your invaluable contributions.



Ravi K
Chairman and Managing Director

CMD's Speech at 63rd Annual General Meeting held on August 28, 2026

Financial and Performance Highlights of the Year

On the financial parameters, the Company recorded an all-time high turnover of Rs. 31,792 Crore for FY 2025-26 driven by consistent order execution and growing demand for indigenous defence platforms. The Company's operational resilience and agility led to a 6% growth from the previous year, despite disruptions in the supply chain. The Profit Before Tax for the year increased by 12% to Rs. 12,112 Crore from Rs. 10,820 Crore in the previous year. The Profit after Tax (PAT) increased by 9% to Rs 9,076 Crore from Rs. 8,317 Crore in the previous year. As of March 2026, the order book position of the Company stood at a healthy Rs. 2,54,538 Crore.

The Company has paid an interim dividend of Rs.35/- per equity share of face value of Rs.5/- each for the FY 2025-26, totalling to Rs. 2,341 Crore. Further, the Board of Directors of the Company has recommended a final dividend of Rs.10/- per share of Rs.5/- each for approval of shareholders, with a cash outflow of Rs. 669 Crore. On approval of shareholders, the total cash outflow for payment of dividend for the FY 2025-26 would be Rs. 3,010 Crore.

The Company incurred Capital Expenditure (CAPEX) of Rs. 2,465 Crore during FY 2025-26 (PY Rs. 2,026 Crore). The investments are mainly channelised towards Green Field Helicopter Project at Tumakuru, augmentation of facilities of LCA, ROH of SU-30, ROH of AL-31FP Engine, IT Infrastructure, besides the regular replacement and rationalisation of the existing facilities etc on the infrastructure development front and on the projects like IMRH, CATS, UHM, Civil ALH & LUH on the Research & Development front.

Aligned with its strategic objectives, the Company has drawn up a robust capital expenditure (CAPEX) plan for the next five years, with a projected investment of around Rs.14,000 Crore. The planned investment will primarily be directed towards expanding manufacturing capacities and establishing Repair and Overhaul (ROH) facilities for various platforms, strengthening the Company's production capabilities and long-term growth.



Research and Development (R&D)

The Company has incurred an expenditure of Rs. 2,794 Crore on R&D during FY 2025-26, which is 8.79 % of the turnover. The Company also transferred a sum of Rs. 945 Crore to R&D reserve for contribution to R&D corpus.

Significant Achievements

Your Company accomplished several significant achievements during the year, some of which are highlighted as under:

- To enhance the production capacity of LCA Mk1A, a 3rd production line was established at HAL Nasik.

- Indigenously designed & developed Advanced Light Helicopter (ALH) Dhruv-NG took maiden flight in presence of Hon'ble Minister of Civil Aviation.
 - The maiden sortie of the first series production Hindustan Turbo Trainer-40 (HTT-40) aircraft successfully completed.
 - Certification for 'Indigenous manufacturing of Shakti Civil Engine' from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) was received.
 - Contributed to ISRO's successful launch of LVM3-M5/CMS-03 mission and LVM3-M6 mission that deployed the massive Blue Bird Block 2 satellite, by on-time supply of space worthy hardware.
 - Signed the SSLV Technology Transfer Agreement with ISRO, IN-SPACe & NSIL, securing a non-exclusive license to manufacture the SSLV.
 - Exported two H-228 (Civil variant) aircraft to M/s JAGS Aviation, Guyana in a record two months of signing the contract, due to proactive approach of the company.
 - Signed an MoU on October 27, 2025 with Public Joint Stock Company United Aircraft Corporation (PJSC-UAC) Russia for production of civil commuter aircraft SJ-100 in India.
 - Signed an agreement with Safran Aircraft Engines in June, 2025, for the industrialization and production of rotating parts for LEAP engines, which powers the single-aisle civil aircraft such as Airbus A320neo, Boeing 737 MAX, etc.
- New Initiatives**
- During the year, your Company has taken many new initiatives which will propel the Company in the future. Some of the significant new initiatives, are as under:
- Attained a significant milestone in its aerospace journey with inauguration of "First Indigenously Developed High Thrust Engine Test Bed- PRAJWALAN" for AL-31FP Engine at HAL Koraput Division.
 - Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed with Mishra Dhatu Nigam Limited (MIDHANI) for Setting up a Strategic Metal Bank for critical raw materials at MIDHANI.
 - Indigenous FADEC design for HTSE-1200 engine has been taken up.
 - Prototype of Rotary Unmanned Aerial Vehicle (RUAV), capable of deployment at high altitudes for cargo delivery and Intelligence, Surveillance, Reconnaissance (ISR) role is built and performance runs are progressing.
 - Ab-initio designed & developed technologies for LCA Mk2 platform.
 - Data Acquisition technology has been introduced in Electrical LRUs i.e., AC & DC Power Management Units for Contactor status, AC/DC source Input current, Essential Bus Voltage, Frequency etc. and their transmission on RS422 line for health monitoring and recording purpose.
 - Optical Level Sensing technology has been developed for aircraft Fuel Tanks Low Level & High-Level warning indication to improve the accuracy, in place of existing capacitance based sensing.
- Future Outlook**
- The Company is intensifying efforts to expand its global footprint through exports and strategic collaborations with international partners. Emerging opportunities in areas such as unmanned systems, advanced materials, digital manufacturing, and space applications are expected to open new growth avenues.
- The Company is poised to sustain its growth trajectory and reinforce its position as a key enabler of India's aerospace and defence capabilities while progressively enhancing its competitiveness in the global market.
- Human Resource Development**
- People remain HAL's most enduring institutional asset. In the year 2025-26, Human Resources focused on strengthening organisational effectiveness, deepening employee engagement, and building the workforce capabilities for our expanding programmes demand. All HR manuals were consolidated into a unified Corporate HR Manual, accessible through a dedicated digital HR Bot, simplifying governance and improving the employee experience. Service recognition frameworks, travel entitlements, medical benefits for dependent parents, and separation settlements were comprehensively revised, reflecting our sustained commitment to employee welfare. A renegotiated Incentive Scheme for Workmen, reinforces the link between performance and reward, sustaining a stable industrial relation environment. HAL's recognition by Department of Public Enterprises (DPE) as a Mentor Organisation for Succession Planning and Leadership Development across peer DPSUs affirms the maturity of our people practices.
- Building capability for the future, the Leadership Development Programme continues to groom our senior leadership pipeline, while the Sponsorship programmes deepens the technical foundation. HAL Management Academy, now an Authorised Training Partner of the Project Management Institute, USA, has broadened its reach considerably. Project Management Teams with certified professionals have been constituted across the Company to drive focused execution and coordination across HAL's growing portfolio of projects. A new Flight Test Engineer Scheme builds the specialised capability in-house,

and initiatives such as Mission Abhyudaya and the Critical Skill Transfer programme are systematically preparing our workforce for smart manufacturing and next-generation aerospace demands.

Corporate Governance

Your Company always strives to conduct the business with integrity, in an ethical and transparent manner to attain the highest standard of Corporate Governance practice in the letter & spirit by framing & implementing various policies & procedures mandated under the Companies Act and SEBI (LODR) Regulations, DPE Guidelines, Public Procurement Policy, CVC Guidelines, MoD directives issued from time to time. The Company has complied with the Guidelines on Corporate Governance framed by the Department of Public Enterprises (DPE) and SEBI Listing Regulations except for the appointment of the requisite number of Independent Directors including Woman Independent Director which led to the non-compliance related to composition of the Board and some of its Committee as indicated in the Corporate Governance Report, forms part of Annual Report. The Company has established systems and procedures to ensure that its Board of Directors is well informed about the policies of the company, to enable them to discharge their responsibilities and to enhance the overall value of all stakeholders. Your company has been continuously rated 'Excellent' grade for the past 24 years with respect to MoU signed with Department of Public Enterprises.



Environment, Social and Governance (ESG)

HAL's commitment to ESG is evident through its focus on environmental responsibility, social development, and robust corporate governance. From reducing water consumption and implementing emission control technologies to its impactful CSR initiatives, and dedication to employee well-being, the Company is actively shaping a sustainable future for India, its stakeholders, and its workforce.

During the year, 200 KW capacity roof top solar power plants have been installed at various locations of the Company. The Company has installed a cumulative capacity of 50.15 MW capacity Renewable Energy (RE) plants out of which 14.7 MW is from wind and balance from solar (ground & roof top). The Company also procured Green power to the tune of 140 Lakh Kwh from DISCOMS. The Company has met around 40% of its electricity requirement from RE sources in FY 2025-26.

The Renewable Energy consumption has avoided around 71000 Tons of CO2e emissions in the reporting year thereby contributing to the mitigation of climate change.

Corporate Social Responsibility and Sustainability Development

Your Company is committed to its social responsibility. In this endeavour, the Company has undertaken various CSR programmes and projects, towards integrating our social and business goals in a sustainable manner in line with Schedule VII of the Companies Act, 2013. During the year, an amount of Rs. 181 Crore has been spent under CSR against the CSR budget/ obligation of Rs. 169 Crore.

Acknowledgement

I take this opportunity to extend my sincere gratitude to the Department of Defence Production, Defence Acquisition Council, Defence Finance, Department of Civil Aviation and our valuable customers viz, the Indian Air Force, Indian Army, Indian Navy, Indian Coast Guard, Border Security Force, ISRO, other Global Aviation Companies and private industry.

I thank DGAQA, DRDO, CEMILAC, Principal Controller of Defence Accounts, Principal Director of Commercial Audit, C&AG, Auditors, Bankers, Legal Advisors, Collaborators, Suppliers, Shareholders and other Agencies and acknowledge their contributions to the Company's achievements.

I am grateful, once again, to the members of the Board for their valuable guidance and acknowledge the immense contribution and dedication of the employees at all levels.

JAI HIND

Sd/-
(Ravi K)
Chairman and Managing Director
with Addl. Charge of Director (Operations)

MOOD CHEERFUL Upbeat Q1 results led by SMIDs, bullish foreign investors, and easing global tensions support indices

Tech Leads D-St Bounce, FPI Play in Focus

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian equities recovered on Friday after a two-day losing streak, with technology stocks leading the rebound. The gains came as investors returned to beaten-down IT shares, while easing crude prices and improving global cues provided some support.

The BSE Sensex rose 330.91 points, or 0.43%, to close at 77,264.51, while the NSE Nifty gained 84.80 points, or 0.35%, to 24,175.65.

August saw the culmination of the June quarter results by the middle of the month, and the results were well accepted by the markets as the positive surprises far outpaced the negatives, according to Dinshaw Irani, MD & CEO at Helios India.

He expects earnings growth of the mid- and small-cap universe to maintain outperformance vis-à-vis largecaps.

Technology stocks led the rebound, with the Nifty IT index gaining 3.5%, helped by strong earnings from US chipmaker Nvidia.



Green Shoots

Index	Last Close	Day	Change (%)		
BSE Sensex	77,265	0.4	1 Month	3 Month	1 Year
Nifty 50	24,176	0.4	0.6	1.8	-3.5
			0.8	1.1	-1.3

Source: ET Data; Compiled by ET Data Team

Tech Mahindra, TCS and Infosys were among the strongest performers.

On the other hand, ICICI Bank, Shriram Finance and ITC were the key laggards.

Foreign investor sentiment has improved after four consecutive months of selling. These funds turned buyers in July and have continued buying in August, too.

"If the recent improvement in FPI flows sustains, we could see a mea-

nful rerating of select large caps, particularly private banks," said Arianth Bardia, CIO and founder of Valtrust. "Overall, we believe the market is entering a phase where earnings delivery, rather than just liquidity, will increasingly drive returns."

Broader markets tracked the benchmark's strength, with the Nifty Midcap and Smallcap indices gaining 0.05% and 0.20%, respectively.

Other sectors such as metals and media also advanced, while banking and financial stocks remained under pressure.

"Large caps appear relatively attractive on valuations and can support lump-sum deployment," said Ankit Garg, fund manager at Wealthy Nivesh PMS. "Mid- and small-caps are closer to their long-term average valuations, but with sentiment yet to turn decisively bullish, we favour staggered allocation in these segments to manage volatility."

Easing geopolitical concerns offered some relief, with Brent crude hovering around \$89 a barrel. Hopes of reopening the Strait of Hormuz have reduced fears of prolonged oil supply disruptions.

India VIX fell 3.70% to 10.66 after rising 5% in the previous session, pointing to easing near-term uncertainty.

Foreign portfolio investors net sold shares worth ₹5,039.80 crore on Friday, while domestic institutional investors bought shares worth ₹5,183.93 crore.

Rupee Rises 17 p on Dollar Inflows



MUMBAI The Indian rupee gained 17 paise on Friday as flows ahead of MSCI

index rebalancing and some dollar sales by state-run banks led a turnaround in the local unit, while dollar sales from importers continued. The rupee closed at 95.37 on Friday, versus its previous close of 95.54 per dollar. Crude oil prices at \$88 per barrel also helped contain weakness, traders said.

The currency is expected to trade between 95.25 and 95.75 levels on Monday. Dealers will now look at comments from Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh's speech at Jackson Hole later on Friday. — **Our Bureau**

\$ 729 billion Forex Kitty Hits a Record

The rise was fuelled by a \$73 b mop-up of non-resident deposits under FCNR scheme

Our Bureau

Mumbai: India's foreign exchange reserves touched a record high of \$729.3 billion as of August 21, after banks stepped up the drive to mobilise NRI deposits under the central bank's concessional swap window in the final two weeks before it closes on August 31.

Reserves increased \$12.4 billion during the week, with foreign currency assets increasing \$9.4 billion to \$591 billion, while the value of gold reserves rose by \$2.8 billion to \$114 billion. Forex reserves last touched a high of \$728 billion late February this year.

As of August 21, Indian banks have mobilised \$65.4 billion in foreign currency non-resident (FCNR-B) deposits under the Reserve Bank of India's special forex swap facility. Total foreign exchange inflows through this specific window reached \$72.85 billion, the RBI said in a statement.

Reserves have increased by \$48 billion since the scheme was announced on June 5.

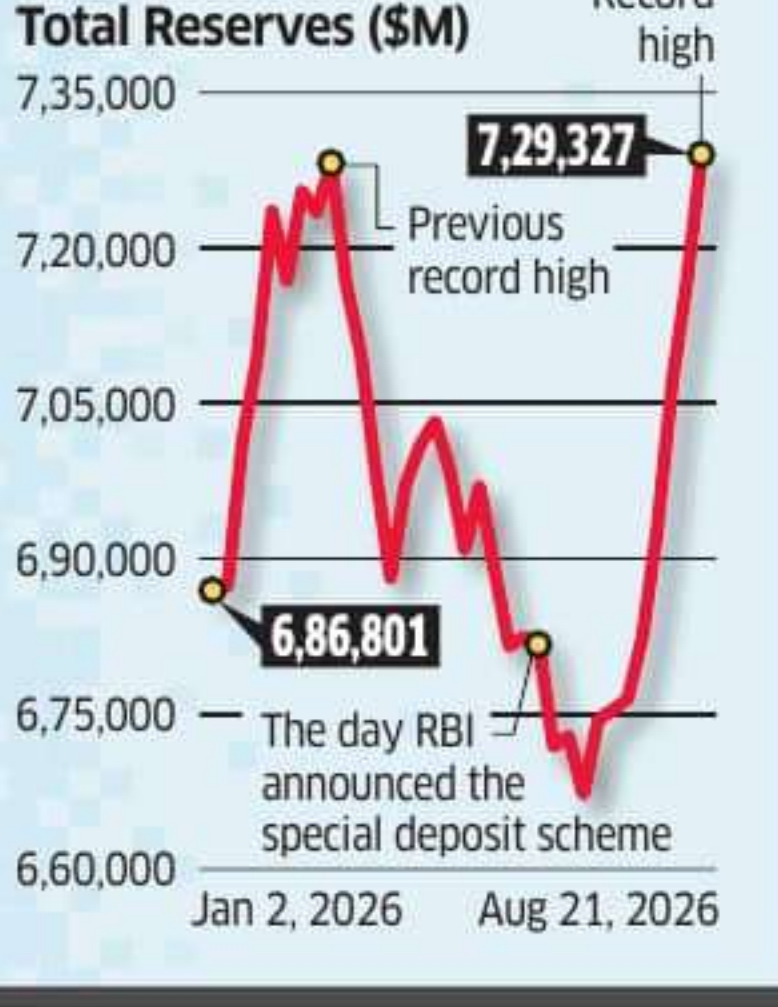
The full \$72 billion in gross inflows will not necessarily be reflected one-for-one in India's foreign exchange reserves. Some of the dollar flows may be used by the central bank to support the rupee through spot market intervention, while a portion may also go toward reducing its outstanding forward liabilities.

The net short forward positions of the RBI stood at \$104 billion as of June 30.

"The rise in reserves is a combination of the RBI buying dollars and a revaluation gain as the dollar index weakened last week. The dollar purchase was led by the FCNR-B swap window, with banks pushing for deposits before the window closes," said Gaura Sengupta, chief economist at



Money Gush



IDFC First Bank.

However, currency traders said the RBI also heavily sold dollars in the spot market, likely defending the 95.75-per-dollar level last week. These dollar sales would have reduced the RBI's overall net dollar purchases even as

strong inflows continued to enter the country. The central bank net bought \$6.1 billion in the week of August 21, according to IDFC First Bank. "The pace of deposit mobilisation by banks in the last week of

the scheme is expected to increase, so I do expect reserves to continue their upward momentum," said Mataprasad Pandey, vice president, Choice Wealth.

Strong momentum via the FCNR-B deposit inflows over the past week has prompted some analysts to raise their estimates for dollar inflows through the scheme. Jefferies India said in a note this week that it now expects FCNR inflows to reach \$90 billion to \$100 billion by the time the scheme closes on August 31, compared with its earlier estimate of \$70 billion to \$80 billion.

RBI Plans Buyback of ₹30K-cr GSecs



MUMBAI The Reserve Bank of India plans to buy back government securities of Rs 30,000 crore on September 3, with all securities listed in the auction maturing in FY27. The aim of the buyback is likely to reduce the redemption burden on the government in the next fiscal year. Securities amounting to over Rs 6 lakh crore are scheduled to mature. — **Our Bureau**

Market Trends

STOCK INDICES		% CHANGE
Nifty 50	24176	0.35
S&P Sensex	77265	0.43
MSCI India	1587	0.35
MSCI EM	4778	0.03
MSCI BRIC	740	0.17
MSCI World	24076	0.11
Nikkei	66406	0.41
Hang Seng	25585	0.07
Kospi(S.Korea)	6789	-1.79
Straits Times	5700	0.28



OIL (\$/BRL)
DUBAI CRUDE
81.46
0.06
Absolute Change

GOLD FUTURES Premium/Discount (\$-144.15)

	Comex US (\$/Oz)	MCX India (₹/10gm)
OPEN	4656.00	158569.00
LAST*	4643.20	159349.00
Prev chg (%)	-0.45	0.22

FOREX RATE (₹/\$ Exchange Rate)

	OPEN	LAST*
	95.51	95.39

*At 6 pm IST Source: Bloomberg, MCX, ET Data
Market on Twitter@ETMarkets

Tempsens Lists at Over Twice IPO Price, Biggest Gainer This Year

Press Trust of India

New Delhi: Shares of temperature sensing and heating solutions provider Tempens Instruments (India) on Friday made a stunning market debut and ended with a massive premium of nearly 96% against the issue price of ₹300.

With the strong market debut, the company became the biggest listing gainer so far this year.

The stock started trading at ₹631.20, registering a jump of 110.4% from the IPO price on the BSE. During the day, it zoomed 111.66% to ₹635. Shares of the firm finally ended at ₹586.80 apiece, surging 95.6%.

At the NSE, the stock listed at ₹634 at a premium of 111.33%. Shares settled 95.55% higher at ₹586.65.

The company's market valuation stood at ₹4,919.30 crore.

With the strong debut, Tempens Instruments surpassed Bharat Coking Coal's over 96% listing gains on January 19 this year.

The initial public offering (IPO) of Tempens was subscribed 184.07 times on the final day of bidding on Monday, driven by an overwhelming response from investors. The price band for the ₹650-crore public offering was fixed at ₹285-300 per equity share.

IN THE RED Nearly half of BSE 200 stocks have given no returns year-to-date, mirroring macro woes in auto, cement, FMCG & IT

Sensex Under Duress, Stress Signs in Broader Market, too

Sachin Kumar and Shailesh Kadam

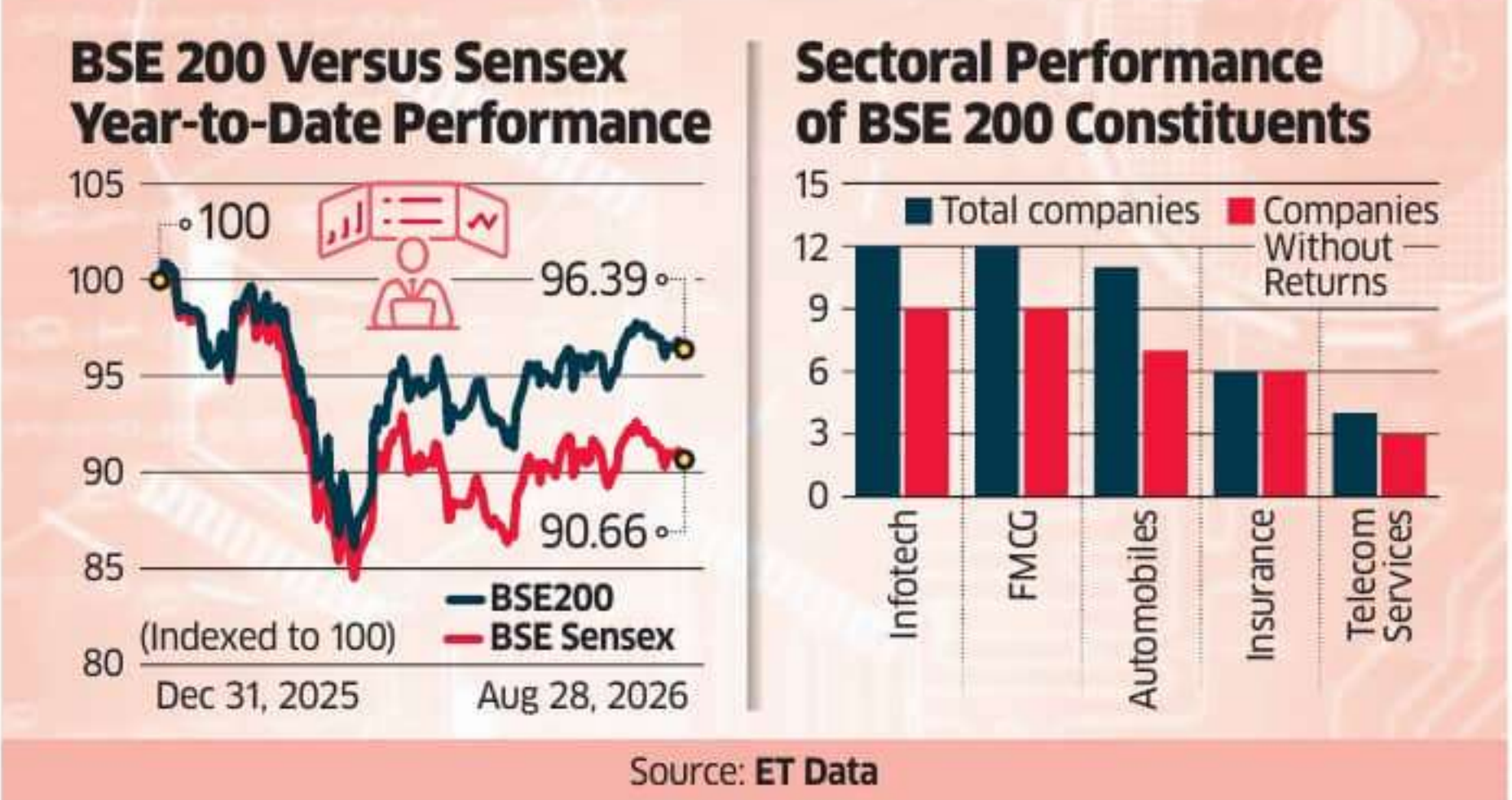
ET Intelligence Group: Nearly half the broader market has failed to generate returns so far this year.

As many as 97 BSE 200 companies, accounting for 49% of the index, have not yielded returns year-to-date. The trend was similar in the first eight months of 2025. This marks a deterioration from the comparable periods of 2023 and 2024, when only 10-20% of the index constituents failed to generate returns.

The benchmark Sensex has declined nearly 9% this year, dropping to 77,264 on August 28 from 85,220 on January 1.

The majority of the companies that did not deliver returns were from sectors including automobiles, cement, FMCG, and IT. The latest trend coincides with the deceleration in incremental systematic investment plan (SIP) flows. After hitting a record ₹32,087 crore in March, monthly SIP inflows have remained below it ever since.

The year so far has not been good for IT, FMCG and insurance companies. Of the 12 constituents from the IT and FMCG sectors in the BSE 200 index, nine failed to



post returns, and none of the six insurance companies did either. IT stocks are facing selling pressure driven by a combination of technology disruption fears, weak discretionary spending, and slower US demand. Brokerages have expressed concerns that AI-driven productivity gains may lead to lower billing volumes and increased pricing pressure.

FMCG stocks have been under pressure this year as investors worry about slowing consumption growth and rising raw material costs, which are pressuring gross margins.

On the other hand, capital goods stocks have outperformed, driven

by higher government spending on roads, railways, power, defence and urban infrastructure. Of the 10 capital goods firms in the index, seven have generated returns so far this year.

Among the index components, Rail Vikas Nigam was the top loser, declining nearly 40% year-to-date, followed by Patanjali Foods, which has fallen 36%, and ITC at 33%. Wipro and Indian Railway Finance Corporation have declined nearly 32% each.

Top gainers include Hitachi Energy, which rose nearly 85%, Solar Industries India, which rose 68%, and Adani Energy Solutions at 57%.

Of A Settlement That was Not, Personal Guarantees & Related Parties

HAIR-RAISING HAIRCUT Bankers question role of RP in the Subhash Chandra case and how net worth was computed, flag need for forensic audit

Joel Rebello

Mumbai: The settlement offered by Zee Group founder Subhash Chandra in the ₹22,000-crore borrowing case has put the spotlight on the personal guarantee process, particularly with regard to personal net worth, creditor qualification and the role of resolution professionals, bankers told ET.

Dissenting banks say unresolved pleas for a forensic audit and asset trailing to be conducted on Subhash Chandra's financials to probe how his networth fell from more than ₹40,562 crore when he issued the guarantees to ₹32 crore in 2025, the crowding out of lenders by related party entities in the committee of creditors (CoC), and the role of resolution professional (RP) Shiv Nandan Sharma in admitting questionable entities as creditors highlight the difficulties in recovery in high-profile cases.

"Banks were facing an uphill battle in this case since it was admitted in April 2024. Chandra's net worth was shown sharply lower; new creditors with dubious credentials were added, and pleas for a proper audit and asset trail were rejected. Banks will have to challenge this till even the Supreme Court because otherwise this will become a model and trend setter for future cases," said a banker closely involved in the case.

'RELATED PARTIES'

Most of the creditors who voted for the ₹6.5 crore settlement for dues of ₹22,006 crore are linked to Subhash Chandra, bankers said.

Veena Investments, which had a 5% vote, is controlled by Chandra's sister-in-law Sushila Devi Goel. Veena subsidiaries World Crest Advisors (28.49%), Direct Media Distribution Ventures (1.15%) and also other creditors Lemonade Capital Advisors (16.85%) and Corpel Capital



Advisors (10.30%) all have directors who were recorded as key management persons in the Essel Group at some point in time.

Together, these related party creditors cornered close to 75% of the vote, much more than the 66% required. Banks and other financial creditors had only 19% of the vote.

Financial creditors, including Canara Bank, HDFC Bank, IndusInd Bank, RBL Bank and IDBI Trust-

eship on behalf of Franklin Templeton had, in different interlocutory applications (IAs), objected to the inclusion related parties as creditors, questioning the fairness and viability of the repayment plan and raising questions on the resolution professional's conduct.

However, judicial member Nilesh Sharma disposed of these IAs without much scrutiny, bankers said.

'LEGISLATIVE ONUS'

For instance, while deciding on the related party entities, the court took a very lenient view, they said, relying on Section 79 (2) (g) of the insolvency code. This provision says that a debtor has to own more than 50% of the share capital in a company to exercise legal control over their boards. Justice Sharma put the onus on the legislature for changing the law while acknowledging that the entities were in fact related to Chandra.

"No material has been produced

showing that the personal guarantor (PG), either individually or together with his associates, as statutorily defined, owned more than 50% of the share capital of the concerned entities or exercised legal control over their boards or governing bodies," Justice Sharma said in his order. "However, there is no doubt about the fact that the said entities are controlled directly or indirectly by the individuals related to the PG. The legislature has adopted legal ownership and control, not commercial influence, as the statutory standard. If experience shows that a wider exclusion is necessary, it is for the legislature, and not the tribunal, to amend the provision."

RESOLUTION PROFESSIONAL

The court found no fault with the RP on the participation of related parties. Failure of RP Shiv Nandan Sharma to appoint an independent forensic auditor or asset-tracing agency to investigate the assets and

financial affairs of debtor Chandra and determine his actual net worth was also glossed over, bankers pointed out, referencing the order.

"The code does not confer upon the RP... a general investigative power comparable to the specific power conferred upon the Bankruptcy Trustee under Section 149... The RP cannot, therefore, be faulted merely for not investigating every past transaction or asset of the PG. The allegation on this count is accordingly not established as a breach of his statutory duty."

Bankers said repeated pleas and complaints against the conduct of the RP were not entertained.

"The conduct of the RP was always doubtful in this case. Despite such serious allegations, the case was expedited and brought to a close. This case had all the ingredients of how a case can be compromised," said a second banker aware of the case.

The RP did not respond to ET's queries in the matter.

Improving Ties with China

From Page 1

New Delhi, in May, updated the standard operating procedure (SOP) for processing FDI applications from these geographies, identifying rare earth magnets and printed circuit boards among 40 sub-sectors for speedy clearance within 60 days. Investors are required to provide details of shareholding pattern, beneficial owners, organisation and group structures, promoters, board composition and key managerial personnel, along with corresponding citizenship status, and details of control rights in the reporting framework.

One industry executive said though the timeline is fixed at 60 days, the amount of paperwork required is substantial, with investors getting several queries that prolong the process of application itself. This came after the government allowed foreign companies having a Chinese or Hong Kong shareholding of up to 10% (or non-controlling stake) to invest in India under the automatic route.

Industry experts, however, said that while the PN2 provided some relief, particularly to private equity players, some issues still remain. Investors from third countries that have been using Hong

Kong as a base have represented before the government on application of rules to ownership structures and arrangements.

"For structures where Hong Kong is only an intermediary layer and the natural person is a Non-LBC (Land Border Country) person/entity, prior approval under PN3 is still required, which defeats the whole interpretation of beneficial ownership under PML Rules," said Anshul Jain, national leader-regulatory, PwC India. "Many foreign companies route their Asia investments through Hong Kong. While they have no LBC ownership and the FDI is coming from Non-LBC locations, but just because the intermediary layer is in Hong Kong, an additional requirement of PN3 approval gets added, which is time consuming and adds uncertainty for these investments."

New Delhi had issued PN3 in 2020 following border tensions with China. Relations between both countries have since improved, with Chinese President Xi Jinping expected to attend the BRICS summit in New Delhi next month.

Mid-Market Consolidation

From Page 1

The proposed transaction comes amid growing expectations of consolidation in the mid-market IT services sector as companies contend with slower discretionary spending, pricing pressure and the disruption caused by artificial intelligence.

Industry executives believe larger IT services firms could increasingly look to acquire smaller or similarly sized rivals, while private equity firms are also exploring opportunities in the segment.

Over the past 12-18 months, several mid-to-late-stage software and services companies have either attracted majority investments from private equity firms or pursued internal consolidation to strengthen their balance sheets and protect margins.

Soota founded Happiest Minds in 2011 after stepping down as chairman of Mindtree, the IT services company he cofounded in 1999. Before that, he was a senior executive at Azim Premji-founded Wipro.

Happiest Minds listed on the stock exchanges in September 2020 following a Rs 700-crore initial public offering (IPO) that was subscribed more than 150 times. Its



SNAPPING UP SMALLER COS
Industry executives believe larger IT services firms could increasingly look to acquire smaller or similarly sized rivals

shares debuted at a 124% premium to the IPO price of Rs 166 apiece. On Friday, Happiest Minds shares ended at Rs 408.10 on the BSE, down 2.9% from the previous close.

Multiple Challenges
At Happiest Minds' annual general meeting on July 28, Soota said the IT services industry had faced a challenging environment in fiscal 2026 because of macroeconom-

ic uncertainty, evolving tariff regimes and geopolitical developments that affected enterprise technology spending.

"At the same time, the rapid advance of artificial intelligence has really emerged as a... defining structural shift. FY26 also marked an inflection point with enterprise AI initiatives moving decisively from pilots to scale production deployments across industries," he said. For FY26, Happiest Minds reported operating revenue of Rs 2,315 crore, up 12% from FY25, while net profit rose 15% to Rs 213 crore.

ITC, too, flagged the challenges facing the IT services industry in its FY26 annual report.

"During the year, the Indian IT services industry faced headwinds due to weak discretionary client spending, delayed project decision making and AI deflation" where AI adoption compressed revenues for traditional services," the report said. "This was compounded by global macroeconomic uncertainty and geopolitical developments."

ITC Infotech reported 14% growth in operating revenue to Rs 4,835 crore in fiscal 2026. Its net profit, however, declined to Rs 408 crore from Rs 450 crore in FY25.

Interoperability Key Issue

From Page 1

BRICS 2025 under Brazil's presidency had emphasised on interoperability of payment systems among member nations to make cross-border transactions easier in the declaration that was adopted. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), which is running a pilot for CBDC, is examining the scope to push cross-border digital transactions within BRICS.

Full-fledged digital currencies are yet to be launched with countries testing various aspects such as uses, applications, and safety. One of the key issues is interoperability that will require aligning technology. Countries including China, a BRICS member, are running pilots for digital currencies.

The summit could also work on realizing the BRICS Agreement on Cooperation and Mutual Administrative Assistance in Customs Matters. Members confirmed their in-principle approval and willingness to sign the agreement to support faster trade, lower transaction costs, secure borders

further, facilitate trusted trade, improve ease of doing business, and tackle illicit trade. On the agenda is also cooperation on global value chains through the Action Plan 2026-30, including a technical council and joint study for enhanced cooperation to ensure global value chains are resilient, efficient and productive; and to advance the opening of markets and economic diversification among BRICS members.

BRICS members, led by India, have also devised a work plan on implementing an invoice discounting mechanism and adoption of the guiding principles for credit assessment frameworks for export-oriented MSMEs. As an industry category, MSMEs are at the vanguard of job creation in India, making up nearly 30% of the gross domestic product and about 40% of merchandise exports.

At the summit, there is also a proposal to launch the digital public infrastructure repository for BRICS countries and pilot projects aimed at digital transformation of the member states.

Peg by Peg, Vodka’s Share is Rising in India

Category’s share rose to 6.1% from 3.8% in 2025, marking a shift towards white spirits, says Radico Khaitan MD

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: Vodka is stealing a record slice of India’s whisky-dominated liquor market, with younger consumers and women driving the sharpest shift ever toward white spirits. The trend has given a fillip to the company that had already premiumised its whisky portfolio.

The vodka category’s share has risen to 6.1% from 3.8% in 2025. It’s a major structural shift which is happening towards the white spirits, especially vodka,” Radico Khaitan MD Abhishek Khaitan said. “Vodka’s mixability is one factor, while flavours are helping bring new consumers into the category,” he said in an exclusive interview.

That marks its biggest jump yet in India and, in a spirits market of about 400 million cases, a one-percentage-point shift represents roughly four million to five million cases.

The incremental volume from vodka’s latest share gain is now



bigger than the entire gin and tequila categories combined. The share gain has come largely at the expense of brown spirits — whisky, rum and brandy — the three largest categories that account for about 90% of the overall market.

Khaitan, who said that until around 2016 he had considered selling Radico Khaitan about three times, spent years building its vodka business before the category’s growth became visible. “It’s taken

that time,” he said. “In the last five years, vodka as a category has grown by 20%.”

The change is being driven by younger consumers and women, as well as the growing popularity of flavoured and more mixable spirits, he said. States including Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh are seeing vodka’s share rise rapidly, with the category gaining ground from whisky, rum and brandy. Globally, vodka accounts for about

28% of the spirits market, leaving India with considerable headroom, Khaitan said. The category has grown about 20% annually over the past five years, but the acceleration has become more visible as the base has expanded.

Radico’s flagship Magic Moments vodka sold 3.25 million cases in the June quarter, up 43% from a year earlier. The company has about 60% of India’s vodka market.

PREMIUM PUSH

Radico’s upmarket move has taken it into a part of the spirits industry once dominated by multinational brands.

For instance, Radico’s whiskies Virasat, aimed at the roughly ₹3,000-₹4,000 price segment, which Khaitan describes as “affordable luxury,” while Rampur ranges from about ₹8,500 to as much as ₹5 lakh. The company had been absent from the middle of that market because of limited malt capacity, he said.

Radico’s premium portfolio gives it less exposure to fluctuations

in grain and glass costs and reduces its dependence on state-level price increases, Khaitan said. It also reflects a deliberate decision taken years ago to move away from commodity selling.

The shift toward premium products has also allowed Radico to

ET Insight

Vodka’s record share gain in a 400-million case market translates into 4-5 million cases per 1 pp gain

reduce its dependence on lower-priced liquor. Its prestige & above contribution has risen to 52% of the portfolio from about 40-43% earlier.

However, the company will retain a regular-price portfolio only in states where it generates adequate margins, Khaitan said. While lower-priced brands offer operating leverage because existing distribution, and manufacturing infrastructure can be utilised, their margins are lower than premium products.

UNCERTAIN FUTURE

Green-Card Interview Pause Casts a Shadow over Indians’ US Plans



Prachi Verma

New Delhi: Spouses, minor children and ageing parents of Indian professionals working in the US, who have been waiting for final green card interviews, are among the worst affected by the Trump administration’s pause on immigrant visa appointments, legal experts said. “It’s not a blanket cancellation of immigrant visa applications, but the pause in interview scheduling adds uncertainty, especially for those with current priority dates who expect to move forward soon,” said Sukanya Raman, country head for India at immigration-focused law firm Davies & Associates.

While the pause is worldwide and non-discriminatory, it could disrupt relocation timelines, marriage plans, children’s education and career plans for applicants, particularly those who had already completed documentation and were preparing for final interviews.

“Previous administrative actions were largely targeted by nationality or specific visa tiers, whereas this pause brings baseline consular immigrant processing to a standstill across every US post worldwide,” said Ankita Singh, founder of law firm Sarvaank Associates.

For Indian professionals and families navigating multi-year permanent residency pathways, though, even temporary administrative halts create cascading scheduling delays and cross-border operational uncertainty, she said. At any given time, thousands of

Indian applicants are waiting for green card interviews. Current queries from applicants to immigration firms include, “How much longer?”

Experts are advising clients to not panic and evaluate options, including whether adjustment of status is possible.

The immediate consequence is procedural delay rather than automatic ineligibility, noted Rohit Jain, managing partner at Singhania & Co.

“But prolonged suspension could cause medical examinations, police certificates or supporting documents to expire, thereby increasing procedural hassle and costs,” Jain said.

Experts are advising applicants to preserve all communications and monitor post-specific instructions.

They expect US consulates to cancel scheduled interviews of family-sponsored and employment-based applicants, or reschedule them without a declared restoration date.

Indian applicants already face substantial statutory queues in several preference visa categories, including EB-2 and EB-5.

From an enterprise perspective, this degree of unpredictability in visa processes for employment in the US naturally accelerates the broader trend toward workforce decentralisation and talent mobility, experts said.

IndiGo Ventures Invests in Artificial Intelligence Startup Sarvam

Our Bureau

Mumbai: IndiGo Ventures, the corporate venture capital arm of IndiGo, has invested in artificial intelligence startup Sarvam AI, joining a 13-investor Series B round as the airline looks to deepen its exposure to technologies that can be deployed across its operations.

The investment takes IndiGo Ventures’ portfolio to four startups, with the fund having committed about ₹600 crore across its investments. IndiGo did not disclose the size of its investment in its announcement on Friday. The airline said the investment would build on its existing work with Sarvam, which includes using AI for customer interactions, employee productivity and operational workflows. IndiGo Ventures has invested ₹30.1 crore, as per reports.

“Artificial Intelligence is fast becoming a foundational capability for the aviation industry, reshaping customer experience, workforce productivity and operational decision-making,” said Neetan Chopra, chief digital and information officer at IndiGo. The investment gives IndiGo access to Sarvam’s AI models, voice technology and agentic systems, while giving the startup a large operational environment in which to develop and test enterprise applications.

“Aviation is a powerful setting for enterprise AI because it combines millions of customer interactions with complex, time-sensitive operations,” Sarvam co-founder Pratyush Kumar said.

Bharti Airtel Adds 26.8 Lakh Mobile Users in July, Jio Adds 24.4 Lakh

PTI

New Delhi: Bharti Airtel led the industry’s July mobile subscriber growth with 26.8 lakh net additions, while India’s largest telecom operator, Reliance Jio, gained 24.4 lakh new users, sector regulator Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai)’s monthly subscription data showed on Friday.

Vodafone Idea, too, added mobile users—its net adds stood at 2.4 lakh for July. State-owned Bharat Sanchar Nigam (BSNL) posted an increase of 1.68 lakh wireless subscribers during the month.

During July, the Indian wireless market expanded by 55.38 lakh mobile subscribers—its base surged to 128.79 crore by the end of July, up from 128.23 crore from the previous month.

“As per the information received from 1,562 operators for the month of July 2026, the total number of broadband subscribers increased from 1087.50 million (108.75 crore) at the end of June 2026 to 1094.48 million (109.44 crore) at the end of July 2026 with a monthly growth rate of 0.64 per cent,” Trai said in its latest report on subscriber count.

For Bharti Airtel, net additions of 26.88 lakh mobile subscribers pushed its wireless subscriber base to 48.94 crore in July. Reliance Jio added 24.46 lakh mobile users in July, taking its total tally of wireless users to 50.60 crore. Vodafone Idea saw its mobile subscriber base rise to 19.90 crore in July, after gaining 2.40 lakh wireless subscribers in the month.

Food Safety Eateries’ Body Says Fix the Problem, Not the Blame

NRAI chief says a collaborative regulatory environment would yield better results

Ratna Bhushan

New Delhi: As some of India’s best-known restaurants, including Paul, Big Chill and Punjab Grill, are being called out over hygiene lapses, National Restaurant Association of India (NRAI) president Sagar Daryani said the focus must be on “fixing the problem, not the blame.”

While “food safety must remain non-negotiable, equally, fairness in enforcement must remain fundamental,” Daryani said in response to ET’s query on a series of lapses reported at some top restaurants

and cafés by consumers and regulators in recent weeks. The allegations have ranged from unhygienic kitchens and expired stocks to incorrect labelling and lack of proper segregation of vegetarian and non-vegetarian foods. “There’s a social media trial that’s going on. A collaborative regulatory environment will achieve far better public health outcomes than one driven by fear or reputational damage,” Daryani said.

French bakery and restaurant chain Paul’s

Food safety must remain non-negotiable, equally, fairness in enforcement must remain fundamental
SAGAR DARYANI
President, NRAI

outlet in One Horizon Centre in Gurgaon and Big Chill Cakery in Delhi’s upmarket Khan Market have been called out by consumers on social media over alleged hygiene lapses, while Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has sealed some outlets, including Punjab Grill and Flint & Warsaw, in recent weeks.

Enforcement efforts should be directed to ensuring that businesses “are given a fair opportunity to address identified gaps without unnecessary loss of reputation, public naming and shaming,” Daryani said. Also, enforcement “must be carried out strictly in accordance with the provisions, intent and procedures under the Food Safety and Standards Act.”

NRAI represents over 500,000 restaurants across India.

Besides standalone restaurants and cafes, even five-star hotels have been called out. Places that have been reported by regulators for hygiene violations at some of their outlets include Domino’s

Pizza, Lalit Ashok, Radisson Blu, Parsi Dairy Farm and Willingdon Sports Club.

Paul India faced widespread criticism after a customer allegation of finding a live worm inside a sandwich went viral on social media. The chain in a statement said it takes “food safety, hygiene and quality standards extremely seriously and that the incident did not reflect its standards.”

Earlier this week, Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) issued notices to Andaz Delhi and JW Marriott hotels in New Delhi’s Aerocity. The regulator said in a social media post that inspections at the five-star properties revealed “serious food safety violations, including seizure of 87 kg of sweets that were past their expiry date at Andaz, and pest infestations at JW Marriott.”

Both hotels are scheduled to host the official BRICS Business Forum, as per the latter’s website. The forum is scheduled for September 12 and 13.

TVS Motor Names Global Biz Head Peyman Kargar as Next Chief Exec

Our Bureau

Mumbai: TVS Motor Company has named its international business head Peyman Kargar as its next chief executive officer, putting him in charge as the two-wheeler maker targets further growth in India and an expansion into developed markets.

Kargar will take over as director and CEO from K N Radhakrishnan on January 27, 2027, TVS Motor said on Friday.

Radhakrishnan will continue as CEO until then and subsequently serve as a non-executive director till the company’s annual general meeting scheduled for July 2027.

The leadership change comes after TVS Motor sold 5.9 million vehicles globally in FY26 and reported 30% revenue growth.

Kargar currently serves as president of international business, which contributes 29% of TVS Motor’s sales volumes and is growing at 33%. He has more than three decades of automotive industry experience across Europe, Asia, Africa and the Middle East.

CIL Fears Coal Gasification Scheme will Blunt its Edge

Says short 60-day bidding window gives big cos with ready projects an advantage

Prashant Mukherjee

New Delhi: Coal India (CIL), the country’s largest coal producer, has told the government that rules for the ₹37,500-crore coal gasification incentive scheme could put it at a disadvantage to private rivals, citing a short bidding window and the exclusion of captive power plants from eligible project costs to calculate the incentive.

The state-run company sought six months for the first round of applications, arguing that the proposed 60-day window favours companies that already have project reports ready. The coal ministry rejected the request, noting that subsequent rounds of bidding will begin immediately after the previous round, with a two-month application period, closes.

A senior Coal India official noted that “applicants have to submit a board-approved feasibility report or project report along with their applications,” giving “undue advantage” to companies whose DPR/PFR is already ready or under preparation.

The timeline matters because financial support for each product

category is capped at ₹9,000 crore across applicants, meaning companies submitting “bids in the initial rounds could secure a larger share of the available support, while projects still complete

MINISTRY NOT CONVINCED
The ministry has rejected Coal India’s arguments in the pre-application conference for the incentive scheme



ting feasibility studies may have to wait,” the person told ET.

CIL has also questioned what costs can be counted while calculating the incentive.

The company asked whether a captive power plant, using rejects from a coal washery to supply electricity to a gasification unit, would qualify as part of the “project” and be included in the project cost and cost of plant and machinery used to calculate the incentive.

The ministry’s answer was categorical, “No. Captive power plants do not fall under the definition of project.”

The exclusion means capital spent on captive power would not form part of the eligible project cost for the incentive.

The official cited above explained that the incentive and inclusion are important for CIL, which is developing projects around its existing coal and washery infrastructure.

CIL—a Maharatna public sector company under the same ministry that framed the scheme—is one of the key potential developers of coal-gasification projects.

The company raised the objections during the ministry’s pre-application conference for the scheme. It is now evaluating the implications as it prepares its bids under the scheme.

India Outpaces APAC Countries in Logistics Rental Growth

Strong demand from manufacturers, e-comm and retailers is driving rents as occupiers look for modern facilities, more efficient networks

Kaillash Babar

Mumbai: India’s key logistics markets continued to outperform the broader Asia-Pacific region on rental growth, supported by sustained manufacturing activity, domestic consumption and the ongoing diversification of supply chains,” said Shishir Bajjal, international partner, CMD, Knight Frank India.

With occupiers placing greater emphasis on operational efficiency and modern, institutional-grade facilities, he expects India’s logistics real estate market to remain on a steady growth trajectory in the near to medium term.

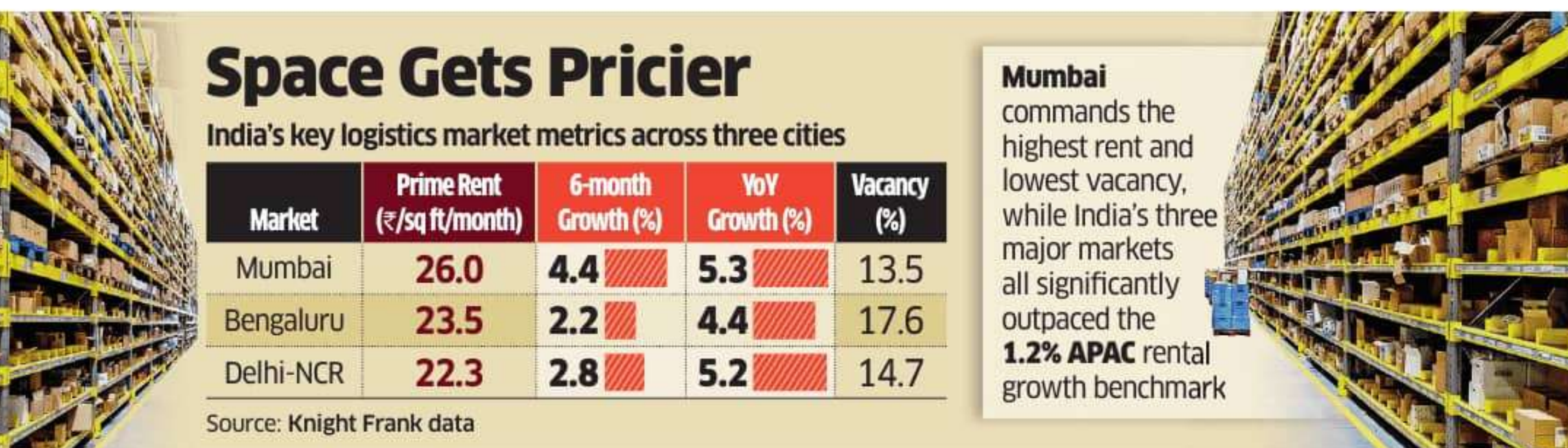
“Rental growth across India’s key logistics markets is strengthening the investment case for institutional-grade warehousing and industrial assets. The market is moving towards larger, professionally managed developments, particularly along established consumption and manufacturing corridors. For developers and investors, this

Asia Pacific logistics market during the period.

“India’s logistics sector continues to demonstrate strong structural resilience, supported by sustained manufacturing activity, domestic consumption and the ongoing diversification of supply chains,” said Shishir Bajjal, international partner, CMD, Knight Frank India.

With occupiers placing greater emphasis on operational efficiency and modern, institutional-grade facilities, he expects India’s logistics real estate market to remain on a steady growth trajectory in the near to medium term.

“Rental growth across India’s key logistics markets is strengthening the investment case for institutional-grade warehousing and industrial assets. The market is moving towards larger, professionally managed developments, particularly along established consumption and manufacturing corridors. For developers and investors, this



creates an opportunity to build portfolios with long-term relevance rather than simply add capacity,” said Anshuman Singh, MD & CEO, IndoSpace. He sees significant headroom for organised logistics real estate as occupier requirements continue to evolve.

COMMERCIAL HUB

Mumbai recorded the strongest rental growth among the three Indian markets, with prime rents

at ₹26 per sq ft per month. Rents increased 4.4% over the six months to June, while vacancy declined to 13.5%. Experts expect further rental growth over the next 12 months, with the market remaining balanced.

In Delhi-NCR, prime logistics rents stood at ₹22.30 per sq ft per month, rising 2.8% during the period and 5.2% annually. Vacancy declined to 14.7%, while the market remained balanced and

the 12-month rental outlook pointed towards further growth.

Bengaluru saw prime rents rise 2.2% over the six-month period and 4.4% year-on-year to ₹23.50 per sq ft per month. Vacancy declined to 17.6%, with the market balance remaining stable and the rental outlook positive.

India’s performance stood out against a more measured APAC logistics market, where 15 of the 18 cities tracked by Knight Frank

recorded stable or increasing rents during the period. Rental growth was constrained in some East Asian markets by elevated availability.

Across the region, leasing activity was increasingly driven by relocations, consolidation and upgrades rather than outright expansion of logistics footprints. Occupiers are becoming more selective and prioritising operational efficiency, network performance and asset quality.

This is strengthening the flight-to-quality trend, with demand increasingly favouring modern warehouses offering better functionality, technology integration and sustainability features.

The demand outlook is also being supported by investments linked to semiconductor and advanced manufacturing supply chains, which are creating additional requirements for logistics and warehousing facilities.



Sports World Play



VITALS

GRAND CHESS TOUR Praggnanandhaa Becomes First Indian to Win GCT Title



St. Louis (USA): Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa became the first Indian to win the Grand Chess Tour title after a stunning comeback victory over Fabiano Caruana of the US in the grand finale on Thursday. Praggnanandhaa trailed Caruana by six points at the start of the day but overturned the deficit to prevail 15-13 and claim his maiden GCT title. The victory also secured the Indian a place in next year's Grand Chess Tour, alongside Caruana and fellow American Wesley So, who finished third after beating Germany's Vincent Keymer 18-12. **PTI**

Neeraj Qualifies for Diamond League Finals

New Delhi: Indian javelin throw ace Neeraj Chopra has qualified for the Diamond League Finals to be held in Brussels on September 5 despite competing in just two events of the prestigious one-day meeting series. Chopra secured 12 points after finishing second in both the Doha and Lausanne DL events on June 19 and August 21 respectively to take the sixth spot in the standings and be eligible to compete in the winner-takes-all grand finale in Brussels. **PTI**

'FIND YOUR OWN ROOM' Japan can't Handle Added Asian Games Numbers

Japanese organisers have told late additions to next month's Asian Games to find their own accommodation, saying they don't have the money or space to deal with ballooning participant numbers. About 15,000 athletes and officials were initially expected at the Games, which are being held in Nagoya and the wider Aichi area from September 19 to October 4. That was already more than the Olympics, but the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA) last week put the number at 17,000 - 11,000 athletes and 6,000 officials. Organising committee president Hideaki Omura told reporters that they had "neither the manpower nor the budget to make the necessary arrangements" for extra participants. **AFF**

An Interview Nearly Put Eng-Pak Test at Risk

PCB considered pulling its players from the second Test after broadcaster aired an interview with Imran's sons during lunch break

The Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) considered withdrawing its players from the second Test against England at Lord's on Thursday after Sky Sports aired an interview with the sons of jailed former Prime Minister Imran Khan, but eventually settled for filing a formal complaint with the broadcaster, sources familiar with the development said. The PCB objected to the telecast of the 18-minute interview with Imran's sons, Sulaiman and Kasim, which was conducted by former England captain Mike Atherton and aired during the lunch break on the opening day of the Test.

Sources said the PCB learned about the interview after Sky Sports ran a teaser for the segment ahead of the match and contacted the broadcaster, asking it not to air the conversation. When Sky proceeded with the broadcast, the PCB considered keeping its players off the field after lunch in protest. Pakistan's players, however, returned to the field as scheduled for the second session.

The PCB subsequently lodged a formal complaint with Sky Sports, expressing its displeasure over the telecast. The board declined to comment when contacted.

Pakistan Television (PTV), which is broadcasting the series in Pakistan, did not show the interview.

The controversy comes as Imran's health and treatment in prison have become a major talking point internationally. The former Pakistan captain's sons used the interview to express grave concerns about their father's safety and medical condition.

Kasim alleged that "blatant" attempts were being made to "kill him in there". "It's very, very clear what they're doing, which is they're just blatantly trying to kill him in there. They just want to keep him in there as long as possible and hopefully just silence him," Kasim said.

He said Imran had told family members that conditions in prison had de-



Former Pakistan captain Imran Khan has been in jail since 2023

AFF

It's clear what they're doing, which is they're just blatantly trying to kill him in there. They just want to keep him in there as long as possible and hopefully just silence him

KASIM Imran Khan's son

teriorated significantly.

"The last time he was able to speak to our aunts and anyone else, he said the conditions have severely worsened recently. He has been relating it to other political prisoners who have been killed or who have died in prison."

"Right now, it is worse than ever, completely isolating him for more than 23 hours a day in a cell," he added.

Imran, 73, was recently taken to Shifa Hospital in Islamabad for a medical examination on the orders of Pakistan's Supreme Court but was returned to prison within hours.

His sons said they remained concerned that he had not been examined by an independent doctor. "We were cautiously optimistic (when the court ordered the medical check-up). Our fears were confirmed when, instead of being taken to the private hospital, where he

was meant to be taken, he was just taken to a government medical facility for a few hours, and then taken straight back to jail," Sulaiman alleged.

"...it just makes us think, what are they hiding? Why are they so fearful of allowing him to get reported on by an unbiased, neutral doctor?" he said.

Sulaiman also said Imran appeared visibly stressed following the examination and had an eye patch.

The brothers said they have not seen their father in person since 2022, when he survived an assassination attempt. They last spoke to him by telephone in March this year and said he had remained stoic despite his circumstances.

Imran has been held at Rawalpindi's Adiala Jail since 2023 after being convicted in corruption cases.

His sons also said their attempts to visit him had been thwarted by visa restrictions. "We tried to visit him. But the visas we applied for were blocked for technical reasons," Kasim said.

Atherton was among 21 former international captains and cricket greats, including India's Sunil Gavaskar, who recently wrote to Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif urging him to ensure proper medical care for Imran. **PTI**

In Shadow of Premier League, Serie A Flexes Financial Muscle

For Italian football this has been a chastening year, yet, ahead of a likely frenzy before their transfer window shuts on September 1, Serie A clubs have spent the summer asserting their place in Europe's financial pecking order.

In both overall outlay and net spend, Serie A is a clear second among the 'Big Five' leagues.

While fee structures, conditional payments and financial sleights-of-hand can make the precise transfer values a little hazy, German site Transfermarkt on Thursday put Italy's total outgoings at more than €1 billion (\$1.165bn), far ahead of La Liga, at three-quarters-of-a-billion, and then the Bundesliga.

In all, the 20 Serie A clubs are almost €430mn in the red this summer, against just under €300mn in Spain. Both the

AC Milan spent a reported €74 million to sign Goncalo Ramos from PSG, making him the most expensive Serie A signing in the last five years

At more than €1 billion (\$1.165bn), Italy's total outgoings in this transfer window are far ahead of La Liga, at three-quarters-of-a-billion, and then the Bundesliga

Bundesliga and French Ligue 1 are in profit.

Of course, the 'Big Five' is a misleading phrase. European club football has become the Premier League and everyone else. English clubs have, so far, spent €3.2bn, more than the other four league put together.

The second round of the Serie A season opens Friday with AC Milan, for now restored to their role as Italy's biggest spenders, hosting smartly-dressed yoyo club Venezia.

When Milan

spent a reported €74mn to acquire Goncalo Ramos from Paris Saint-Germain, he became the most expensive Serie A signing since Juventus bought Dusan Vlahovic from Fiorentina five years earlier.

With Diego Moreira, coming from Strasbourg for €50mn, Milan have spent a total of almost €160mn, a whisker more than Juventus, with plenty of moves to come.

Under new boss Ruben Amorim, Milan opened the season with a 2-1 win at Torino.

On Thursday, Amorim did not rule out further recruits. "We have to wait five more days until the transfer window closes," the Portuguese coach, who started last season in the Premier League with Manchester United, told his pre-match press conference.

"If someone arrives, it will be because they can help us both now and in the future."

AFF

WATCHOUT! Tonight

PREMIER LEAGUE Liverpool v Nottingham 5pm; Tottenham v Newcastle 10pm (Star Sports) **LA LIGA** Sevilla v Atletico 1am (Fancode) **BUNDESLIGA** Dortmund v Hamburg 10pm (Sony Ten)

Future of Indian Women's Hockey is Bright: Savita

Amstelveen: India's women's hockey team has found a new belief in itself, veteran goal-keeper Savita Punia said after the side finished fifth at the World Cup, their best result in more than five decades.

The result marked a strong turnaround for India, who failed to qualify for the Paris Olympics in 2024 and suffered a heartbreaking exit from the semi-final race at the World Cup.

Savita, who has 319 international caps, said the biggest change was not simply reflected in the results but in the atmosphere within the dressing room. "The coaching staff has created

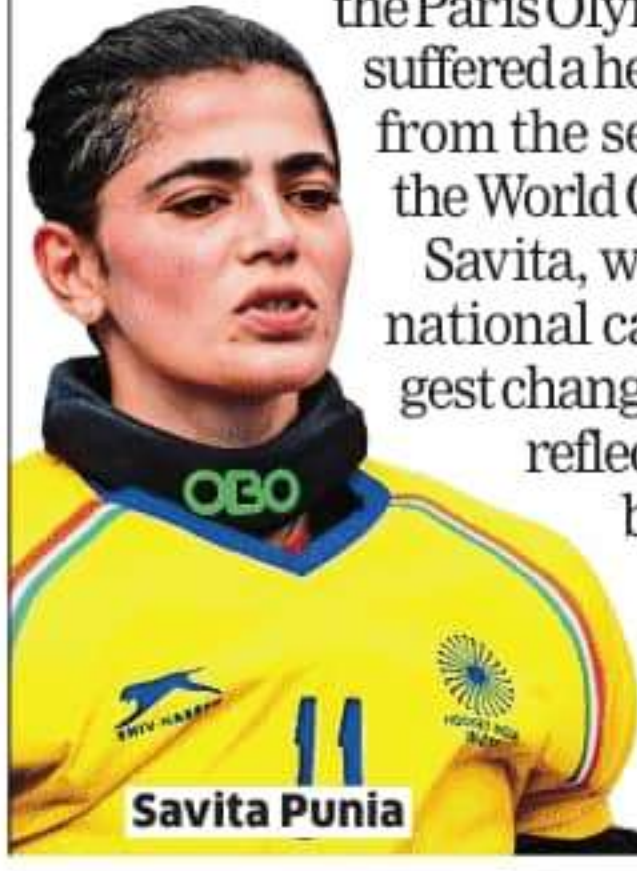
such an environment that we feel a deep sense of doing our best. It's visible in the eyes, in the workouts and in the practice of all the players," said Savita, who is one cap away from equalling India's record for most international appearances.

While celebrating the team's fifth-place finish, Savita has also used social media to call for the revival of the Women's Hockey India League, saying the young players who emerged during the campaign need a platform to continue their development.

"This was the first World Cup for these 11 players, and they performed brilliantly. This suggests that the future of Indian women's hockey is bright," she said.

India lost just one match during their campaign, going down 3-0 to the Netherlands. For Savita, the progress offered reason for optimism as India look to build on their resurgence. **PTI**

India finished 5th at the World Cup, their best result in 52 years



Savita Punia

When we came in January, we had a list of about 20 injuries and now we have finished fifth in the World Cup. It says it all

DR WAYNE LOMBARD strength and conditioning coach

It has been a journey with many ups and this is what we have to continue, but that's only possible when we stay hungry and eager to get the best out of ourselves and not take things easy. Growing is a daily process and also staying connected with each other

SJOERD MARIJNE chief coach

When Meals Became Binding Contracts



DEVDUTT PATTANAIK Author

Have you ever been curious as to why Jews keep Kosher, Muslims keep Halal, or why Hindu and Jain Banias are strictly vegetarian? All these are trading communities. All have, for centuries, used food practices to establish a network of trust in global trade.

Long before the institution of insurance and credit control systems, faith in trading was built upon food. From Jewish traders in the Mediterranean to Muslim traders in the Indian Ocean, and Jain and Marwari traders in India, food restrictions were an important part of the architecture of trust among traders who never crossed paths.

The same predicament united traders on faraway shores, despite their differences and disparate conditions. Each trader would hand over goods or capital to a person located on distant shores, with a limited or no chance of ever travelling there. How could they be sure the recipient would not abscond with the money? A state contract was of no use on faraway shores, but a way of eating was transportable. Dietary law functioned as a signalling mechanism because it was costly to fake. Its uniqueness lies in the fact that while many can claim to be honest, few will actually uphold a lifetime of dietary restrictions, fasting schedules and rituals of food preparation for a deception.

As a Jewish trader sat down to eat in Cairo or Fustat in the 12th century alongside other Jews, he was not simply practising religion in the privacy of his own domain; he was marketing himself. Anyone looking would understand that this man was a member of a certain community, was known to that community's networks in other locations, and would negatively impact his standing, including his marriage and the well-being of his children, if he transgressed that community's law of trade. Historians of the Cairo Geniza have shown that Jewish Maghribi traders developed reputation systems spanning the entire Mediterranean. It is documented that news of a cheater in Alexandria would reach Tunis within a week, and a man would be completely cut off from trade.

Similar logic applies to Muslim

Kosher, Halal and Jain diets signalled trust, turning food laws into passports for global trade

trade networks spanning from Arabia to Malabar to East Africa. Islamic commercial law enabled merchants to have a common code of contract and partnership law that operated in any port with a mosque. The mosque, along with the prescribed times of prayer and Halal practice, were part of the infrastructure of commerce. A merchant in a different port could enter the mosque and determine who



kept the fast and correctly observed it, thereby locating people bound by the same law. This mechanism enabled Hadhrami and Gujarati Muslim merchant families to construct trading empires that continued to exist long after any single ruler or port city.

Jain and Marwari merchants in India created, perhaps, the strongest iteration of this framework. Their strict vegetarianism and avoidance of root vegetables, along with very specific fasting periods, made it very difficult, almost impossible, to fake over a lifetime.

Since these were also predominantly endogamous trading castes, discipline in both food and marriage cemented each other. A Jain merchant from Rajasthan sent to a distant trading post had a set of habits that any other Jain merchant could authenticate, and that substituted for a credit check a stranger would never be able to conduct.

All three cases demonstrate conversions from ritual to economic infrastructure. Food laws are difficult to forge, are evident in daily routines and are enforced by an entire community as opposed to a single court or ruler. This enabled people to identify and organise networks of trust with individuals to whom they could extend credit. They were able to punish members of their new networks for infractions of conversions from ritual to economic infrastructure. Food laws are difficult to forge, are evident in daily routines and are enforced by an entire community as opposed to a single court or ruler. This enabled people to identify and organise networks of trust with individuals to whom they could extend credit. They were able to punish members of their new networks for infractions of

trust by excluding them from the network, regardless of where the infraction occurred.

It is important to note that none of these practices were initially devised as trade tools. They all had a logical framework and a moral origin: Jainism has compassion, Judaism has covenant and Islam has submission to divine law. What trade added to these systems was the recognition that these costly and visible systems could act as a passport and a credit reference. Trade did not form the basis of the systems; it added to their purpose.

NON-SEQUITUR



Silk Stalkings



Reshmi Dasgupta

There is something innately frightening about water. There is a pent-up power, a latent fury, an inexorable about it. And the mid-week glacial avalanche that briefly dammed a Himalayan river and then burst it, triggering a deadly mudslide from Tibet that devastated parts of northern Nepal, just reinforced my lifelong fear of water. Much like the 2004 tsunami devastation forever coloured my impression of sparkling sandy beaches and 'serene' ocean vistas.

Swimming pools, cascading fountains and rain-shower stalls in bathrooms are just about as much as my nerves can take when it comes to water. It is, of course, hard to imagine that the liquid that sits so demurely in a glass or in a bottle can morph into such a terrifying avatar when rolling down a mountain gorge or pounding against a shore during a storm. This Jekyll and Hyde quality of water makes it surely one of the most deceptive of nature's elements.

My own travels with the seepage in our south Delhi home is emblematic of the relentlessness of wa-

Respect Water, Not Disregard It

The latest Nepal flood reiterates that water can give both life and death

ter. One corner of our basement sprouts a large damp patch no matter how many times the area is scanned, grouted and plugged. A tiny crack is invariably missed, and the water works its way in once again. This vexatious cat and mouse game has been going on for the past 20 years. In this case water's implacability is not frightening but it certainly is frustrating. Indeed, if that menacing damp patch influenced my opinion of water in any other form than contained peacefully in a receptacle, the videos going around for the past two days of idyllic Himalayan valleys and even a solid concrete immigration building being swept away by 30-foot-high walls of debris-charged water in the blink of an eye simply reinforce my fear. Can there be a more eloquent warning from Nature about the need to respect her tremendous force?

Once upon a time "floods" were something we Indians associated with rural areas: crops destroyed and villages drowned by monsoon swelled rivers. Our geography books invariably mentioned the Huangho or Yellow River being called "China's Sorrow" as its devasta-

ting floods killed millions of people down the millennia. But now floods are a city phenomenon too, with rainfall-induced urban inundation further demonstrating the destructive potential of water.

Yet humans continue to build concrete jungles, dodge regulations to conserve and recharge water and dam rivers for our energy and irrigation needs. In fact, every nation with the requisite wherewithal does much the same, to fulfil the aspirations of their people. Everyone loves the "beauty of Nature" and we Indians sing peans to our rivers and seas in

the national anthem, but do we truly respect these powerful and essentially unpredictable repositories of water?

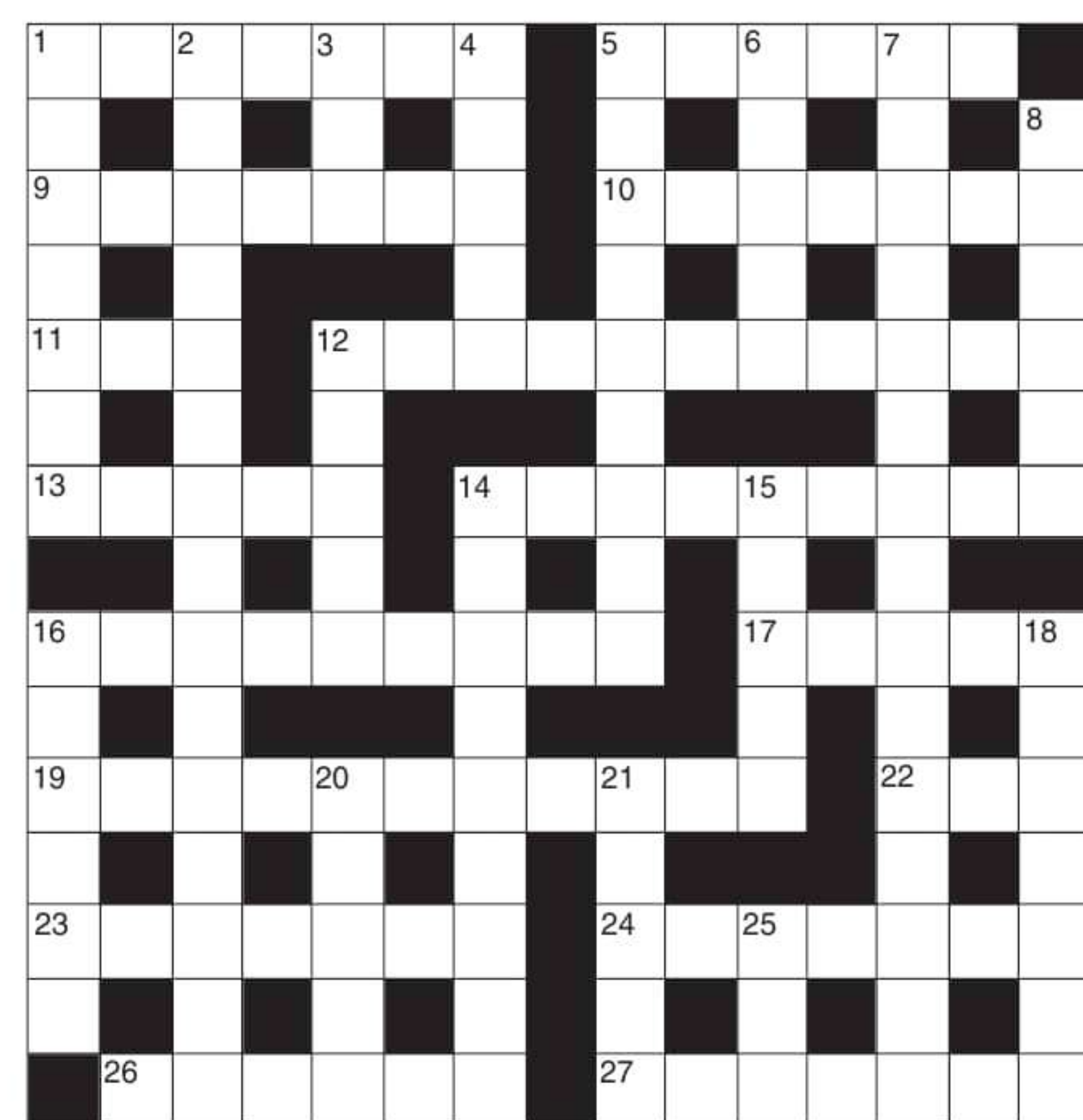
The latest "liquid concrete" flow of water from the Himalayas has far too many precedents in India and Nepal; what happens on the Chinese side during such events is hard to gauge but it must be

just as bad. It seems we are wilfully ignoring Nature's repeated signals to slow down, accept the realities of our fragile eco-systems and manage expectations accordingly. 'Development' cannot exclude those who live in remote areas but nor should it endanger them.

Ironically, water gives both life and death; it all depends on which avatar is invoked by our actions. These days, efforts to harness the life-giving aspects of water often have the opposite effect. Just look at how many irrigation and hydel power projects get destroyed each year by catastrophes like glacial avalanches or cloud bursts. Are we at fault or Nature? We have our compulsions and She has hers. Do we have the will or inclination to modify our actions?

Crossword

9690



ACROSS

- 1 Pampers group amid Greek island sun (7)
- 5 Material for publication about a new awning (6)
- 9 Barman swimming with daughter gets swimming aid (7)
- 10 Foreign language article showing coffee bean (7)
- 11 It carries passengers in suburb, usually (3)
- 12 Takes for cooking after short time thinly cut piece of meat (6,5)
- 13 Disprove Scottish detective ignoring second lead to take (5)

DOWN

- 12 Direct stop curiously showing sign on road (9)
- 16 Dockworker to serve at sea having received education (9)
- 17 Suggest this person's trick, nothing less (5)
- 19 Model slates style in a vulgar fashion (11)
- 22 Badly damaged vehicle, say, reported in park (3)
- 23 Block therefore occupied by business student (7)
- 24 Come back again and strive for work around island (7)
- 26 Final character with energy in large

amounts is fanatical sort (6)
27 Black substance left in a mine haphazardly before November (7)

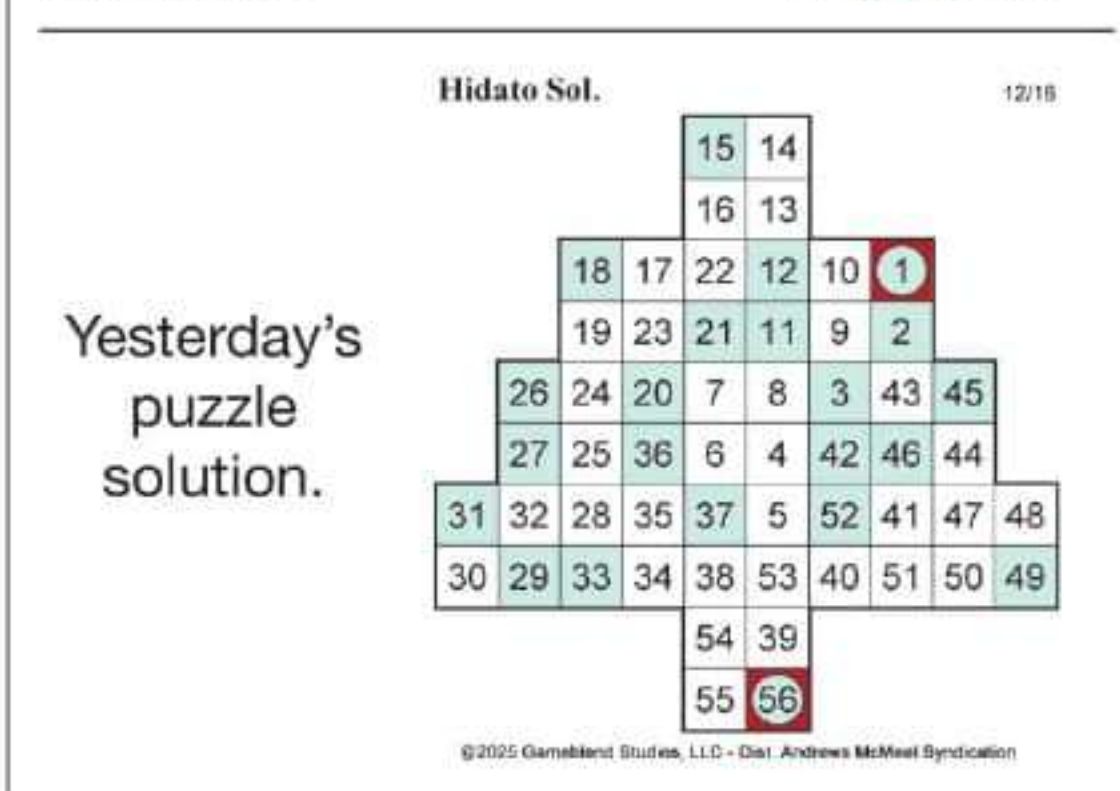
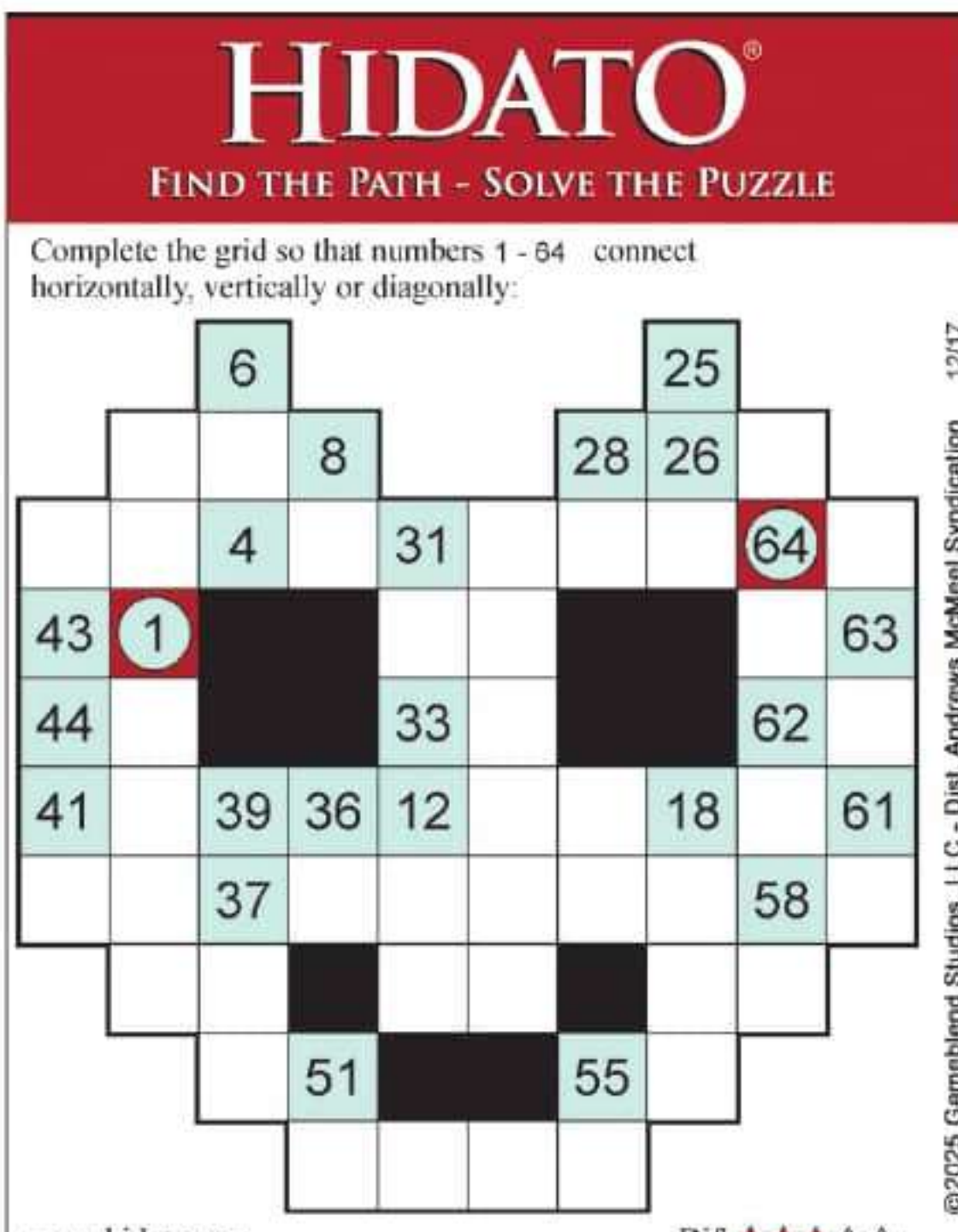
DOWN

- 1 Ascend with difficulty last part of trail fringed by curve on road (7)
- 2 Beers Miles ordered to cover route on reserve type of marine craft (15)
- 3 Long period in another aquarium (3)
- 4 African country held up in a dust storm partly (5)
- 5 Price including a range of goods in area for tourism? (9)
- 6 Approaches note on things needed for audition (5)
- 7 Comic prone to wander around capital in evaluation of different retail outlets (5,10)
- 8 Request to probe regular parts of chest, box for valuables (6)
- 12 Dull paint is endless problem (5)
- 14 Idiot touring Kent area also held up plant (9)
- 15 Female flipping fruit over yard (5)
- 16 Group with place for driving gets somewhere to sit (6)
- 18 Expression of disgust shortly over a function in Mexican state (7)
- 20 Sign up loner needing organisation (5)
- 21 Self-contained and peculiar feature of rugby (5)
- 25 Woman given appreciation (not half) (3)

SOLUTION TO NO. 9689:

- ACROSS: 1 Bear witness. 9 Charlie. 10 Imports. 11 Alb. 12 Make out. 13 Unclear. 14 Nit. 15 Elena. 17 Sadly. 18 Coomb. 20 Pay up. 22 Rho. 24 Smelter. 25 Bisects. 26 Ava. 27 Against. 28 Laid out. 29 Excessively. DOWN: 1 Blanket coverage. 2 All done. 3 Wheat. 4 Tributary. 5 Expects. 6 Street directory. 7 Iceman. 8 Astray. 16 Euphrates. 18 Casual. 19 Botanic. 21 Passive. 23 On-site. 25 Balti.

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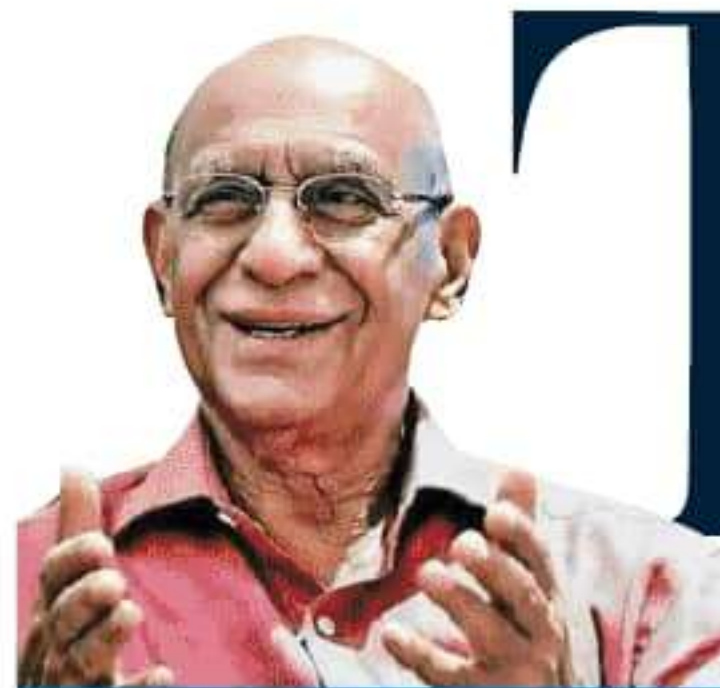
7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 some Broadway productions (8)	_____
2 Taylor Swift's beau Travis (5)	_____
3 more jubilant (7)	_____
4 going back on one's word (8)	_____
5 ride for the Oscars, perhaps (4)	_____
6 pigsties (6)	_____
7 like some sunglasses (9)	_____

IZ	REV	LS	MO	IER
EG	SS	RR	AR	KE
POL	LCE	ME	IVA	LI
ME	ED	ING	REN	ES

Yesterday's Answers: 1. OHIOANS 2. PENS 3. DASHBOARD 4. APES 5. SONGWRITERS 6. WISEST 7. ZUCCHINI



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India has offered to deploy NDRF teams in Nepal to help with rescue operations following devastating flash floods. At least 320 Indians are missing ► P 2

► ITC Infotech to Acquire Controlling Stake in Happiest Minds from Ashok Soota ► Clarifications Soon on Rules for FDI from Neighbouring Countries: P1



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